

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Aquifer Open Study Notes

Revelation 1:1

The word revelation (Greek apokalupsis) introduces the book's visionary nature as apocalyptic writing (see Revelation Book Introduction, "Apocalyptic Writing"). God communicates his inspired message through mysterious symbols, numbers, and word pictures.

- from (or of) Jesus Christ: He is both the source and the main subject of the book.
- the events that must soon take place: Cp. [3:11](#); [22:6-7](#); [Luke 18:8](#); [Rom 16:20](#).

Revelation 1:1-11

Revelation opens with a three-part introduction, including a prologue ([1:1-3](#)), a letter introduction ([1:4-8](#)), and a historical introduction ([1:9-11](#)).

Revelation 1:2

reported (Greek martureō) ... testimony (Greek marturia): These closely related Greek words indicate an authentic witness and emphasize that the sacrificial witness of Jesus and the authentic testimony of John are the basis for the revelation.

Revelation 1:3

God blesses: Revelation contains seven promises of blessing ([1:3](#); [14:13](#); [16:15](#); [19:9](#); [20:6](#); [22:7](#); [14](#)). • listen . . . and obey: Authentic hearing entails obedience.

Revelation 1:4

To the seven churches does not mean that there were only seven churches in the Roman province of Asia but that these seven churches represent the entire group. Grace and peace is a typical Christian greeting (see study notes on 2 Cor 1:1-2; 2 Thes 1:1-2). The order of the two words is consistent in the New Testament, suggesting that peace follows from God's grace. • who is, who always was, and who is still to come: God controlled the past, will

surely control the future, and is sovereign over every present crisis (see also [Rev 1:8](#); [4:8](#); [11:17](#); [16:5](#)). • the sevenfold Spirit (literally *the seven spirits*): Some argue that the "seven spirits" are seven angels, but the phrase fits between references to God the Father ([1:4](#)) and to God the Son ([1:5](#)), making this passage a description of the Trinity (see [Matt 28:19](#); [John 14:26](#); [15:26](#); [2 Cor 13:14](#); [1 Pet 1:2](#)). The number seven acknowledges the Holy Spirit's perfection (cp. [Zech 4:2](#), [6](#), [10](#)).

Revelation 1:4-8

The second introduction (see study note on 1:1-11) is in the style of a Greek letter.

Revelation 1:5

Jesus is our model for proclaiming the Good News of salvation ([1:2](#)). (2) The truth that Jesus was the first to rise from the dead is foundational to Christian faith ([1 Cor 15:14](#), [17](#)). (3) As ruler of all the kings of the world (see also [Rev 17:14](#); [19:16](#)), he is the absolute Lord of everything. Inhabitants of the Roman world were expected to declare Caesar as absolute lord; many early Christians died for their conviction that Jesus alone holds that position.

Revelation 1:5-6

In this doxology, John gives reasons for praising Jesus. • Doxologies often conclude with the confessional Amen (see [Rom 11:36](#); [Phil 4:20](#)), which expresses affirmation.

Revelation 1:8

I am is the name of God in the Old Testament ([Exod 3:13-14](#); [6:2](#); [Deut 6:4](#)). Jesus applied this name to himself (cp. [John 4:26](#)). Alpha and Omega are the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet; they signify that God's actions are all-encompassing. God is fully in control.

Revelation 1:9

your brother and your partner: Though separated from other Christians by his imprisonment, John shared a sense of community with them in suffering, based on hope in God's Kingdom and a willingness to endure. • The Roman fortress on the island of Patmos housed prisoners and exiles. Patmos was in a group of islands that protected the thriving seaport of Miletus. • for preaching . . . and for my testimony: In typical Semitic parallelism, the second statement means essentially the same as the first. By John's time, Jews were persuading Roman authorities that Christianity was different from Judaism and therefore not an authorized religion.

Revelation 1:9–11

This third introduction (see study note on 1:1–11) is historical; it shows God communicating with humanity in historical events. God gave John a significant mission while in exile.

Revelation 1:10

the Lord's Day: This designation was used in the Roman world to refer to celebrations in honor of Caesar, but Christians used it to refer to their weekly worship, celebrating Jesus' resurrection. The earliest Christians worshiped in Jewish synagogues on the Sabbath, the last day of the week ([Acts 18:4](#)), but by the time of Revelation, they were excluded from synagogues and gathered on the day that commemorated the resurrection, the first day of the week (see study note on Luke 24:1; see also [Acts 20:7](#)). • The loud voice like a trumpet blast was an announcement of the Lord's coming.

Revelation 1:11

Write . . . and send: God authorized John as a prophet and herald of his revelation (see [22:8](#), [10](#); cp. [Isa 6:8–9](#); [Jer 2:1–2](#); [Ezek 2:1–3](#); [34:1–2](#)).

Revelation 1:12

I turned to see who was speaking: This statement refers to the loud voice of [1:10](#). • seven gold lampstands: The lighted menorah was a symbol of

God's presence among his people ([Exod 27:21](#); [Lev 24:1–4](#)) and of his all-seeing eyes in the world ([Zech 4:10](#)).

Revelation 1:12–20

John's first vision is a symbolic picture of Christ as the wise, secure, and powerful agent of God who always cares for his people.

Revelation 1:13

the Son of Man (or *a son of man*): *Son of Man* is a title Jesus used for himself (see [Dan 7:13](#); [Matt 8:20](#); [9:6](#); [16:13](#); [Mark 2:28](#); [9:9](#); [14:41](#); [John 1:51](#); [3:13](#); [5:27](#)). • The long robe and gold sash give Christ an authoritative appearance (see [Rev 19:13–16](#); [Dan 10:5](#)). The robe was a priestly garment symbolizing purity and holiness.

Revelation 1:14

White hair represents wisdom and maturity; this vision reflects Daniel's vision of the Ancient One ([Dan 7:9](#)). • His eyes . . . like flames of fire pierce through pretense; the One who knows everything will judge everyone (see [Dan 10:6](#); [Heb 4:13](#)).

Revelation 1:15

Refined or hardened bronze in the feet implies stability, firmness, and security (cp. [Dan 10:6](#)). • The thundering voice suggests God's power—when he speaks, he will be heard (cp. [Ezek 43:2](#)).

Revelation 1:16

The seven stars represent the complete church. The church is secure in the right hand (i.e., in the acceptance and blessing) of the Son of Man. • The sharp . . . sword coming from his mouth is his effective message and his judgment (see [19:15](#); [Gen 3:24](#); [Eph 6:17](#); [Heb 4:12](#)). Jesus proclaims both grace and judgment, but here the emphasis is that he carries out judgment (see [Rev 2:12](#), [16](#); [19:15](#), [21](#); cp. [Isa 11:4](#)).

Revelation 1:17

When I saw him, I fell . . . dead: Terror and a dead faint, if not death itself (see [Exod 33:20](#)), frequently result when someone sees God (see [Isa 6:1-5](#); [Matt 28:4](#)). The Lord graciously responds by the touch of his right hand (cp. [Matt 25:34](#)) and the words “Don’t be afraid!” (cp. [Luke 1:13](#)), indicating both grace and acceptance. • I am: The phrase identifies Jesus as God (see study note on Rev 1:8).

Revelation 1:18

the living one: Because the Son of Man ([1:13](#)) has conquered death, he holds the keys of death and controls the outcome of our greatest fear (see [20:14](#); [Heb 2:14-15](#)). Jesus has complete authority to provide hope in a hostile world. • the grave: Greek *Hades*. See study note on Rev 6:7-8.

Revelation 1:19

Write: In the vision, God gives instructions for what John is to do on his behalf (see [Isa 6:9-10](#)). This vision’s purpose is to help the church ([Rev 1:20](#)) understand the present and the future from God’s perspective.

Revelation 1:20

John is to record what he sees because Revelation is an instructive word for the churches. • The angels (or *messengers*; Greek *angelos*) of the seven churches could be (1) the guardian angels of these churches (cp. [Matt 18:10](#); [Acts 12:15](#)); (2) the leading officials of the churches (cp. [Matt 11:10](#), where “messenger” is *angelos*); or (3) a personification of the *ethos* of the church. The best understanding is probably a combination of 1 and 3.

Revelation 2:1

Write . . . to the angel: This repeated command that introduces each of the seven letters suggests the importance of the message. • Ephesus had become the main city of the Roman province of Asia. It contained the temple of Artemis (see [Acts 19:23-35](#)) and became the richest banking center in that part of the world. The people of Ephesus were very

independent; they declined help from Alexander in rebuilding their temple after it was destroyed (300s BC), arguing adroitly that one god should not stoop to build a temple to another god (see Strabo, *Geography* 14.1.22). The Ephesians’ protective pride also led to the uproar against Paul ([Acts 19:23-41](#)).

Revelation 2:1-7

The letter to the church in Ephesus addresses tradition-bound Christians who are faithful but have lost their early, zealous love for Christ and for each other (see [2:5](#)).

Revelation 2:1-3.22

The seven messages to the seven churches reflect the state of Christ’s church when Revelation was written, and it is similar today. God still calls Christians to faithfulness and integrity. Those who heed Christ’s message will reap God’s promised rewards; those who fail to do so will be judged.

Revelation 2:2-3

I know: This repeated refrain ([2:9](#), [13](#), [19](#); [3:1](#), [8](#), [15](#)) shows Christ’s total knowledge of his people, their activities, and their circumstances. • The Ephesian Christians had a correct theology marked by perseverance and faithfulness. They had examined various claims, exercised discipline on evil people, could tell what is true and what is false, and had patiently suffered for their faith in Christ.

Revelation 2:4

You don’t love me or each other as you did at first: When the church was first established, their love for Christ and for each other had been strong. Struggles with false teachers and persecution had caused that original love to grow cold. Correct theology, action, and even suffering ([2:2-3](#)) are just an empty shell of Christian life if dynamic love is absent ([1 Cor 13](#)).

Revelation 2:5

Christ calls even those who keep the faith to turn back to him and repent of cold-heartedness. The warning, I will come and remove your lampstand, means that they would lose their status as a church; God would treat them as he did the apostates within Israel (see [Rom 11](#)).

Revelation 2:6

Not much is known of the Nicolaitans, but their teaching ([2:15](#)) seems to link them with those who ate food sacrificed to idols and who were involved in sexual immorality, behavior prohibited by the council in Jerusalem (see [Acts 15:20, 29](#)). Irenaeus argued (about AD 180) that the Nicolaitans were dependent on Nicolas ([Acts 6:3–5](#)) and that John's writings were directed against the heresies of the Nicolaitans who followed Cerinthus (see 1 John Book Introduction, "Setting").

Revelation 2:7

The reward for obedience is fruit from the tree of life—that is, eternal life ([22:2](#); [Gen 3:22](#)).

Revelation 2:8

The seaport village of Smyrna had been destroyed and rebuilt several times. Like Christ, the city had been dead but was now alive. It is the only city of the seven that has survived to this day (Izmir, Turkey).

Revelation 2:8–11

The letter to the church in Smyrna pictures suffering Christians under intense pressures who need a message of assurance. Smyrna typifies a small church that remains faithful to God despite difficult circumstances.

Revelation 2:9

Jesus connected material poverty with the blessing of being rich in God's Kingdom ([Matt 5:3, 10–12](#); [Luke 6:20](#)). • Jews who had no faith are condemned for aligning themselves with Satan in hostile

opposition to the Christian faith ([Rev 3:9](#); see [John 8:44](#); [Acts 14:2–5](#); [17:13](#); [18:6](#); [20:3](#); [Gal 5:11](#); [1 Thes 2:14–16](#)). At the Jewish council of Jamnia, the Jews excluded Christians as unholy heretics. John was not anti-Semitic; he was a Jew describing the actions of fellow Jews against Jewish and Gentile Christians.

Revelation 2:10

John saw the devil as the source of human hostility against Christians. • The period of their suffering would be ten days, symbolizing a limited time of persecution (see [1 Pet 1:6](#)). If they would remain faithful, their reward would be the crown of eternal life. • when facing death: John's pupil Polycarp was a martyr in Smyrna in the mid-100s AD.

Revelation 2:11

Faithfulness until death is described as being victorious; overcoming the second death means receiving eternal life (see [20:5–6, 14](#); [21:8](#)).

Revelation 2:12

Christ's sharp two-edged sword indicates that these Christians would receive the Lord's most severe judgment (see [2:16](#); see study note on 1:16). The *two-edged sword* was the Roman symbol of authority, which typified Pergamum as capital of the province. If the church failed, the true governor of the city (Christ) would turn his authority against them.

Revelation 2:12–17

The letter to the church in Pergamum portrays Christians who are tempted to compromise their morality and their loyalty to God. The city of Pergamum was the earliest capital of the Roman province of Asia. It contained a famous library, and its citizens developed the use of animal skins as writing materials.

Revelation 2:13

The throne of Satan might refer to the altar of Zeus on the mountain above the city or to emperor

worship at the temple of Augustus. For many years, the Roman proconsul had his throne there, and the great temple of Athena and other shrines were also located in Pergamum. Its description as Satan's city might also refer to the temple of Asclepius, whose symbol was coiled snakes. The city was dedicated to the Roman pantheon and emperor worship. • Antipas is otherwise unknown.

Revelation 2:14–15

Some in Pergamum were syncretists, combining Christianity with paganism and engaging in immoral activities. John compares them to Balaam, who lured Israel into sin (see [Num 25:1–3](#); [2 Pet 2:15](#); [Jude 1:11](#)). • Nicolaitans: see study note on Rev 2:6.

Revelation 2:17

Those who remain faithful to Christ will receive manna, nourishment from heaven (see [Exod 16:11–36](#)). • hidden away in heaven: During the Exodus, a jar of manna was placed in the Ark of the Covenant ([Exod 16:33–36](#)). Jewish tradition said that at the coming of the Messiah, the Ark would reappear and manna would be eaten at the messianic banquet. Jesus is the bread from heaven and the bread of life ([John 6:32–35](#); cp. [Exod 16:4–21](#)). • A white stone was often given to victors in athletic competitions, and it was common for special banquets or festivities to use a white stone for admission. It therefore suggests acceptance and victory. • The new name probably refers to the recipient's transformed nature in Christ (see [Gen 17:5](#); [32:28](#); [John 1:42](#)).

Revelation 2:18

Thyatira was an outpost city known for its many trade guilds, including weavers and dyers ([Acts 16:14](#)). • The flaming eyes of the Son of God indicate penetrating perception; the solid feet portray Christ's stability, in vivid contrast to the famous Colossus of Rhodes, an enormous statue which had once been thought to be firmly planted until an earthquake destroyed it in 226 BC.

Revelation 2:18–29

The letter to the church in Thyatira confronts Christians who mix Christianity with pagan practices and a worldly lifestyle.

Revelation 2:19

Christ emphasizes knowing and seeing all things as he praises the Thyatirans.

Revelation 2:20–21

The mention of Jezebel, who led Israel into pagan idolatry and immorality ([1 Kgs 16:31–33](#); [21:5–26](#)), indicates a serious problem. Like the Old Testament queen who led the pagan cult of Baal (see [1 Kgs 16:31](#); [18:4](#); [19:1–3](#)), this unknown Jezebel called herself a prophet but was leading God's people into various forms of immorality, including sexual misconduct and straying from God into idolatrous alliances and actions ([Exod 34:15–16](#); [Ps 106:39](#); [Isa 57:7–8](#)).

Revelation 2:21

Through messengers such as John, Christ had given this false prophet opportunity to repent of her sinful teachings and actions, but like many, she had refused (cp. [9:20–21](#)).

Revelation 2:22–23

Christ's judgment on this "Jezebel" and her followers comes in three stages: (1) Jezebel is on a bed of suffering; (2) her followers will suffer greatly; and (3) her children will die (cp. [Acts 5:5, 10](#); [1 Cor 11:30](#)). This judgment echoes the plagues on Egypt that ended with the deaths of Egypt's firstborn sons (see [Exod 12:29–30](#)). • God sees thoughts and intentions (see [Jer 17:10](#); [Acts 1:24](#); [Heb 4:12–13](#)), and he gives whatever sentence people deserve (see [Rev 22:12](#); [Jer 17:10](#); [Matt 16:27](#)).

Revelation 2:24

The depths of Satan might be a striking reference to the Gnostic god named "Depth" (*Bythos*), who

with his partner “Silence” (*Sigē*) formed a philosophic godhead. Gnosticism placed great emphasis on secret knowledge.

Revelation 2:26–28

Christ promises that those who are obedient will share authority with him, as symbolized by the iron rod that will smash the opposition like clay pots (quoting [Ps 2:8–9](#); cp. [Rev 12:5](#); [19:15](#)). • The morning star is the planet Venus, which signals the coming of a new day. Here it refers to the promise of resurrection at Christ’s return ([22:16](#); [2 Pet 1:19](#)).

Revelation 3:1

Sardis, nearly 50 miles (80 kilometers) east of Smyrna on the southeast highway from Pergamum and Thyatira, was home to a large colony of prosperous Jews, called “Sephardic” after the city’s ancient name. Its fortified acropolis gave its inhabitants an overconfident sense of security. • a reputation for being alive—but you are dead: Other churches may have believed that the Sardian Christians comprised a dynamic church, but their secularism revealed their lack of spiritual life.

Revelation 3:1–6

The letter to the church in Sardis warns Christians who are reputed to be spiritually alive (when actually dead) that without genuine transformation they face God’s judgment.

Revelation 3:2–3

The church of Sardis needed to wake up or it would suddenly fall. The city of Sardis had fallen when the forces of Cyrus (549/546 BC) and of Antiochus III (189 BC) made unexpected attacks through a secret tunnel and caught the watchmen off guard. The same would be true of the Christians there if they did not meet the requirements of ... God (see [20:12](#); [Eph 2:10](#); [Jas 2:20](#)). • as a thief: Like the invaders in the city’s history, Christ would come suddenly (see [Rev 16:15](#); [Matt 24:43](#); [1 Thes 5:2](#); [2 Pet 3:10](#)).

Revelation 3:4

Soiled . . . clothes represent an impure life ([Zech 3:4](#)), while white clothes depict purity (see [Rev 6:11](#); [7:13–14](#); [22:14](#)). • Walk expresses how a person lives (see [Gen 17:1](#); [Pss 81:13](#); [82:5](#); [Rom 8:4](#); [Gal 5:16](#)).

Revelation 3:5

Having one’s name recorded in the Book of Life (see [20:12–15](#); [Dan 7:10](#)) symbolizes having assurance of God’s acceptance and eternal life (see [Rev 17:8](#); [20:12](#); [Phil 4:3](#); see also [Luke 10:20](#)). For God to erase a name implies condemnation and eternal death (see [Exod 32:32–33](#); [Ps 69:28](#)).

Revelation 3:7

Philadelphia was situated in the foothills of the Timolus Mountains, open to fertile plains in the east. The city repeatedly experienced severe earthquakes that left it weak and impoverished. • This verse quotes phrases from [Isa 22:22](#). • key of David: Jesus the Messiah is successor to David’s royal line. As the gatekeeper of heaven, Jesus has authority to open and close the way to heaven (cp. [Matt 16:19](#)).

Revelation 3:7–13

The letter to the church in Philadelphia encourages Christians who seem to be weak and powerless to realize that their true strength is in Christ. This comforting message includes no words of disapproval. The Kingdom of God does not depend on human strength or wisdom but on God’s power and authority.

Revelation 3:8

I know: See study note on 2:2–3. • little strength: Like the city of Philadelphia itself (see study note on 3:7), the Christians there were not prosperous, and they lacked status and power. But Christ had opened a door for them (see [3:7](#)) to claim his status and authority. In spite of their weakness, the Philadelphia church obeyed Christ’s word and did not deny him under pressure.

Revelation 3:9

those who belong to Satan's synagogue: The Christians in Philadelphia had suffered maltreatment by anti-Christian Jews (see study note on 2:9). • bow down at your feet: In the ancient world, captives were often forced to prostrate themselves before their conquerors (see [Isa 49:23](#); [60:14](#)). The church's human enemies will ultimately acknowledge that Christians are the ones God loves.

Revelation 3:10

Jesus will protect Christians who persevere through trials (cp. [Isa 43:2-4](#); [John 10:27-28](#); [1 Cor 10:13](#); [Heb 6:18-19](#)). • The great time of testing refers to the end times, when the world experiences tribulation.

Revelation 3:11

Christians must hold on; they must persevere in difficulty so they will not lose their crown, their expected reward.

Revelation 3:12

Victorious Christians are secure in God's household since, like pillars, . . . they will never have to leave it. • The name of . . . God that is inscribed on them portrays God's ownership and the security Christians thus enjoy (see [7:4](#); [14:1](#)). • The new Jerusalem is not a realm constructed by humans, but is God's gift from heaven ([21:2-10](#)). • A new name was a sign of God's blessing (see also [2:17](#)); Abram, Jacob, Simon, and others were given new names ([Gen 17:5](#); [32:28](#); [John 1:42](#)).

Revelation 3:14

Laodicea, situated 40 miles (65 kilometers) southeast of Philadelphia, was the economic and judicial center of a metropolitan region that included Colosse and Hierapolis. The citizens of Laodicea were very proud of their self-sufficiency. After a severe earthquake (AD 60), Laodicea refused aid from Rome and rebuilt their city themselves (Tacitus, *Annals* 14.27), making it very beautiful. • the Amen: Used as an oath, "Amen" is a

promise of truth ([Isa 65:16](#)). Jesus is the truth ([John 8:32](#); [14:6](#)), and his message is authenticated by the truthfulness and reliability of his word. • The description of Christ as the faithful and true witness declares that he knew them as they really were: Though wealthy and proud of their status and accomplishments, they were not measuring up to God's expectations.

Revelation 3:14-22

The letter to the church in Laodicea castigates lukewarm Christians whose inconsistent lives stand for nothing but themselves. They sicken Christ to the point of his spitting them from his mouth.

Revelation 3:15-16

neither hot nor cold: The hot springs in Hierapolis were famous for their healing qualities. Colosse was equally famous for its cold, refreshing springs. In contrast, the water available in Laodicea was smelly and lukewarm. Such water is distasteful; Jesus was saying that the church's indecisive commitment to him was revolting.

Revelation 3:17

Although Christians in Laodicea felt prosperous and self-sufficient (see study note on 3:14), Jesus accurately saw their wretched and miserable and poor spiritual condition.

Revelation 3:18

Jesus' prescription for Laodicea required a complete change of attitude from self-reliance to dependence on God. • buy gold from me: Materially, they could buy whatever they wanted, but they needed to acquire the treasures of heaven so they would have spiritual riches through faith in Christ. • purified by fire: While material wealth will not withstand God's purging *by fire* (cp. [1 Cor 3:12-15](#)), spiritual wealth has eternal value. • White garments represent spiritual purity. Black wool cloth and garments were prized exports of the city of Laodicea. This famous black wool cloth was a source of Laodicea's material wealth; it probably represents the Laodiceans' proud and unredeemed

spiritual condition. • Laodicea's material prosperity was also due to their well-known Phrygian eye ointment, which may have been used there in the eye clinic associated with the famed physician Demosthenes Philalethes. The Laodiceans needed to buy *ointment* from Christ through faith. Only his eye salve would enable them to see their sin and repent.

Revelation 3:19

Christ will correct and discipline those whom he loves ([Prov 3:11-12](#); [Heb 12:5-6](#)), rather than rejecting them. His faithfulness extends even to the unfaithful ([2 Tim 2:13](#)).

Revelation 3:20

A person or a church must hear Jesus knocking and open the door to him. Christ provides a pattern of revival for a church that has grown spiritually weak and fallen out of fellowship with him. Simply opening the door can renew their former bond. • we will share a meal: A shared meal symbolizes acceptance, deep friendship, and a covenant relationship ([19:9](#); see [Gen 18:1-5](#), [16-19](#); [Exod 12:1-31](#); [18:12](#); [Matt 26:26-30](#)).

Revelation 3:21

The reward for victorious and obedient faith is to sit with Christ on his throne. Christians do not become divine, but they share in Christ's victorious reign ([20:4](#), [6](#); [22:5](#); [Col 3:1-4](#); [2 Tim 2:12](#)).

Revelation 4:1

Then . . . I saw: This introductory phrase (see also [7:9](#); [15:5](#); [18:1](#); cp. [19:1](#)) does not signal chronological sequence but the beginning of a new visionary experience. • Come up here: The voice of the Lord invites John to look at things from God's perspective.

Revelation 4:1-11

The description of God's throne room stretches the imagination. It builds on the visions of [Isa 6:1-4](#), [Ezek 1:4-28](#), and [Dan 7:9-10](#), where God is seen

enthroned in power and majesty. God's throne dominates Revelation, and the worship in the rest of the book flows from this scene. God's magnificence, grace, and glory are fundamental to the church's worship.

Revelation 4:1-5.14

This section introduces the visions and judgments to come. John presents God in his heavenly court—the scene of the drama of Revelation ([4:1-11](#))—and the Lamb, who has a central role ([5:1-14](#)). John contrasts the majesty of God with the so-called majesty of Caesar. God's power and splendor is unequaled by the ceremonial court of any earthly ruler.

Revelation 4:2

By being in the Spirit, John could experience spiritual realities (see [1:10](#); [17:3](#); [21:10](#); [Ezek 11:1](#)) and grasp insights about God's presence, the heavenly realm, and God's intentions in history.

Revelation 4:3

Rather than painting a visual picture of God ([Exod 20:4](#); [Deut 4:15-19](#)), John uses gemstones and the rainbow ([Gen 9:8-17](#); [Ezek 1:28](#)) to suggest God's qualities. The rainbow speaks of God's grace as it recalls God's covenant with Noah ([Gen 9:13-17](#)) that he would never again destroy the earth with water. In Revelation, however, we see the earth destroyed by fire (cp. [Gen 19:24-29](#)).

Revelation 4:4

The twenty-four elders on their thrones probably represent all of God's people. They might correlate to the twelve tribes of the old covenant and the twelve apostles of the new (see [21:12-14](#)), although some have identified them with the twenty-four divisions of the Israelite priesthood ([1 Chr 24:1-19](#)). In the drama, they act as an antiphonal chorus (alternating groups of speakers or singers).

Revelation 4:5

The thunder that follows flashes of lightning is God's call to attention (see [8:5](#); [11:19](#); [16:18](#)). • in front of the throne were seven torches: In ancient times, torches were set before rulers to show their authority. These torches with burning flames represent the perfect Spirit of God.

Revelation 4:6

a shiny sea of glass, sparkling like crystal: The most eye-catching part of ancient theaters was the glistening mosaic where the speaking orchestra was positioned to provide perspective (cp. [15:2-4](#)). • The four living beings represent the whole created order. • covered with eyes: This phrase probably indicates that they had knowledge or understanding. In the ancient world, figures were covered with a particular feature to emphasize that quality (e.g., statues of Artemis were covered with breasts to emphasize fertility). Cp. [Ezek 1:18](#).

Revelation 4:7

These four creatures symbolize four types of beings: a lion represents wild animals, an ox represents domesticated animals, a human represents humanity, and an eagle represents the birds (cp. [Ezek 1:10](#)). These four figures are drawn from [Ezek 1](#) (cherubim) and [Isa 6](#) (seraphim). They probably represent the best of creation as worshipping God. Missing from this worldwide orchestra are fish, which ancient people associated with the evil sea (see [Rev 21:1](#)), and insects, represented by locusts in the evil kingdom (see [9:1-11](#)).

Revelation 4:8

day and night: The four beings ceaselessly praised God's basic characteristics: his holiness, his power (the Almighty), and his eternity (see study note on 1:4). • Holy, holy, holy comes from [Isa 6:3](#) and is the highest worship affirmation in Scripture. To double something makes it emphatic; to triple it makes it ultimate.

Revelation 4:9-11

The antiphonal chorus of twenty-four elders provides divine perspective on creation. • The one sitting on the throne is typical Jewish indirection to avoid speaking God's name.

Revelation 4:11

You are worthy: This phrase is never used of God in the Old Testament but was frequently used in Rome during emperor worship. As emphasized here, only God deserves worship. • you created all things: Many in the ancient world believed that the gods were too busy to be concerned with humans. But God is Almighty in more than a philosophical sense; he is involved as Creator and Lord. In Revelation, creation affirms that God is in sovereign control of the world (see [3:14](#); [10:6](#); [14:7](#); [21:1](#)). • they exist because you created what you pleased: God had a purpose for everything that he created.

Revelation 5:1

The scroll, like a dramatic script, details God's plan for the world ([Ps 139:16](#)). • The right hand represents God's gracious authority and power (see [Rev 1:17, 20](#)). • The writing on the inside and the outside means that God's plans for history are full and complete. • sealed with seven seals: God has put his purposes for history in an impermeable safe ([Isa 29:11-12](#); [Dan 8:26](#)). His purposes will be completed only when the seals are broken (see [Rev 5:4](#)).

Revelation 5:1-14

John introduces the Lamb, Jesus Christ, the central figure of Revelation and God's chosen agent for accomplishing his purposes.

Revelation 5:2-3

At first, no one in the entire universe seemed to have the divine authority or power to answer the angel's call.

Revelation 5:4

John wept because even though the revelation had been promised to him, he thought he would be denied knowledge of the divine script—God’s plan for history ([4:1](#); see [10:4](#)). John’s weeping highlights the significance of the anticipated revelation.

Revelation 5:5

Designations for Jesus as the Lion of . . . Judah (see [Gen 49:9–10](#)) and the heir to David’s throne (see [Isa 11:10](#)) are Old Testament metaphors for the Messiah (see [Jer 23:5](#); [30:9](#); [John 7:42](#)). • Because Jesus won the victory at the cross ([John 16:33](#)), he is the only one worthy to open the scroll and reveal God’s purposes ([Rev 4:11](#); [5:2](#), [12](#)). God’s plan for history centers around Jesus and what he has done. His relationship to the scroll indicates his control of history.

Revelation 5:6

The Jews expected the Messiah to appear as a conquering lion. Instead, Jesus came as a Lamb ([John 1:29](#), [36](#); [Acts 8:32–35](#); [1 Cor 5:7](#); [1 Pet 1:19](#)). The Lamb that had been slaughtered but was now standing refers to Jesus’ death and resurrection. • The Lamb’s seven horns represent his complete power, and the seven eyes represent his complete knowledge (see [Zech 4:10](#)). He is also fully related to the perfect Spirit of God ([Rev 1:4](#)).

Revelation 5:8

fell down before the Lamb: The crucified and risen Christ has divine authority to initiate the events of this age; he is fully worthy of worship. • The prayers of God’s people become a significant basis for the judgments and plagues ([6:9–11](#); [8:2–5](#)).

Revelation 5:9–10

The whole created order joins in a new song of praise to the Lamb (cp. [14:1–5](#); [Ps 149:1](#); [Isa 42:10](#)). • The Lamb is worthy because, through his sacrifice, he won the right to break the seals of the scroll and enact God’s purposes in history. • The

song summarizes the implications of the Good News about Jesus ([1 Pet 1:18–25](#)).

Revelation 5:10

The description of God’s people as a Kingdom of priests who will enjoy ultimate victory and will reign with Christ reflects the images of Jesus as both King ([Rom 1:3](#)) and High Priest ([Heb 6:20](#)).

Revelation 5:11–12

A huge angelic chorus numbering thousands and millions provides an antiphonal response; all heaven responds to creation’s confession of Christ’s sacrifice.

Revelation 5:12

This doxology ascribes to Jesus divine honors that are reserved for God alone (see [4:11](#); [5:13](#); [7:12](#)).

Revelation 5:13

The second antiphonal response resounds from every creature, even those under the earth (the place of the dead) and in the sea (usually associated with evil), possibly implying a mandatory response even by those in rebellion against God ([Isa 45:23–25](#); [Rom 14:11](#); [Phil 2:10–11](#)).

Revelation 5:14

The dramatic introduction of the Lamb ([5:1–14](#)) closes with the living beings ([4:6–9](#)). Their Amen affirms the truth of what John had seen, as the twenty-four elders prostrate themselves in worship.

Revelation 6:1–8

The four horses and their riders (see [Zech 1:8–11](#); [6:1–8](#)) sum up the power structures of the world; their activities primarily lead to war, violence, economic imbalance, and death. It is pointless to put our hope in these power structures.

Revelation 6:1–8.1

The Lamb breaks the seven seals to reveal the significance of history from God's perspective.

Revelation 6:1–16.21

Three sets of seven judgments—the seals, trumpets, and bowls—form the core of Revelation. Some suggest that the judgments form a chronological sequence from beginning to end, with each set of judgments flowing from the seventh judgment of the previous set for a total of twenty-one successive judgments. More likely, the relationship is cyclical (as in other Jewish apocalyptic works; cp. [Dan 2](#), [Z 8](#), [11](#)), with each set conveying increasing intensity and adding new details of God's judgment on those who rebel against him. In this perspective, all three cycles end at the same chronological point, with the return of Christ.

Revelation 6:2

While some have understood the rider on a white horse to be Christ, as in [19:11](#), the only similarity between these two images is the horse. The four riders represent the destructive, senseless world and show no redeeming qualities. • The bow was typical Greco-Roman military hardware; here it is a symbol of war. • win many battles . . . gain the victory: The double use of the Greek word *nikaō* (conquer) confirms that this rider is powerful. The focus on war and conquest illustrates human depravity.

Revelation 6:3–4

The red horse represents bloody violence on the earth. Although peace was what the Roman Empire promised (the *pax Romana*), widespread violence was the horrible reality. This rider represents slaughter, including civil upheavals and ethnic cleansing.

Revelation 6:5–6

The black horse represents economic and social dysfunction, indicated by scales used in commerce. Rampant inflation is shown by the cost of the

staples of life: A loaf of wheat bread or three loaves of barley will cost a day's pay. Yet the prices of luxuries such as oil and wine would remain unchanged. It is an image of social and economic imbalance.

Revelation 6:7–8

With the fourth seal comes a ghastly looking horse. In the ancient world, pale green was the color for depicting a corpse. • the Grave: Greek *Hades*. In Greek thought, Hades was the underworld abode of bodiless beings. The Hebrew idea of *Sheol*, the place of the dead ([1 Sam 28:15](#)), was similar. • The killing of one-fourth of those on earth indicates that the final judgment has not yet arrived (contrast [Rev 6:16–17](#)). • This fourfold set of woes (sword and famine and disease and wild animals; cp. [Ezek 14:21](#)) summarizes the tragedies of earthly existence. The world cannot offer hope to humanity.

Revelation 6:9

Rather than follow the world's destructive ways, the martyrs gave their lives for the word of God.

Revelation 6:9–11

In counterpoint to the world's destructive ways ([6:1–8](#)), the fifth seal introduces Christian martyrs who ask how God intends to deal with evil.

Revelation 6:10

The martyrs shouted to the Sovereign Lord because they trusted in his power to redress their grievances. • how long: Is God slow to act? Will justice be done? God does act decisively (see [6:12–14](#)); his wrath ([6:16–17](#)) must be understood in terms of justice, fairness, and righteousness (see [Exod 34:5–7](#); [Neh 9:17](#); [Pss 103:8](#); [145:8](#); [Joel 2:13](#); [Jon 4:2](#); [Rom 2:6–11](#)). • avenge our blood: This cry for God's justice follows the pattern of imprecatory (vengeance) psalms (see [Pss 6:3](#); [74:10](#); [79:5](#); [80:4](#); [137:1–9](#)). It also reflects the covenant curses of [Deut 28:53–57](#); [32:35](#) (quoted in [Rom 12:19](#)).

Revelation 6:11

A white robe is symbolic of the martyrs' victory and of God's full acceptance. • they were told to rest: Death is a state of rest (cp. [John 11:11-12](#)) in which martyrs await God's justice. • the full number: Only God knows how many Christians will be martyred before the end. In his sovereignty, God will fulfill his purposes through his children who are martyred and will vindicate them at the appropriate time. • brothers and sisters: Greek adelphoi; this term refers to people, both male and female, who are members of the same family.

Revelation 6:12-14

These cataclysmic signs are associated in Scripture with the day of the Lord, when God's judgment will overturn the whole created order (see [Isa 13:4-12](#); [34:1-4](#); [Joel 2:1-32](#); [Zeph 2:1-3](#); [Mark 13:1-37](#)).

Revelation 6:12-17

The opening of the sixth seal offers a glimpse into the end of the created order.

Revelation 6:15-17

hid themselves: In the face of God's judgment, unredeemed people will be terrified and seek a safe hiding place, but in vain ([Isa 2:19-21](#); [Ezek 38:20](#); [Hos 10:8](#); [Luke 23:30](#)). The prophets repeatedly warned that the great day would be a day of wrath and judgment ([Isa 13:6-11](#); [Joel 1:15](#); [Amos 5:18](#); [Zeph 1:14-15](#)). • The ultimate question concerning God's judgment is, who is able to survive? ([Mal 3:2](#)). God's children will rejoice to see him ([Rev 5:13-14](#); [14:3-5](#)) because they understand God's response to the martyrs' cry for vengeance ([6:9-11](#)), and they themselves have nothing to fear from God's judgment ([Acts 10:34-36](#); [Rom 5:1-2](#)). Those who have persecuted God's people, however, will quake in fear as they face the wrath of the Lamb.

Revelation 7:1-3

Wait! God calls for a temporary halt by the four angels of destruction. • The seal of the living God implies membership in God's household; God owns and protects his people ([2 Cor 1:22](#); [Eph 1:13-14](#)).

In the ancient world, sealing or tattooing was a sign of ownership. • The angel . . . carrying the seal identified God's people, answering the question of who would survive God's wrath ([Rev 6:17](#); see [Ezek 9:3-8](#); [John 17:14-15](#)) and furthering the promise of protection ([Rev 3:10](#); see also [11:1-2](#)).

Revelation 7:1-8

The interlude's first vision shows how God protects his faithful followers from ultimate harm.

Revelation 7:1-17

Three interludes occur in chs 6-14 (ch 7; [10:1-11:14](#); [12:1-14:20](#)) to define the place of God's holy people and to provide perspective on the previous scenes. In this first interlude before the seventh seal is broken, two visions communicate how God protects his people and assures them of his calling.

Revelation 7:4-8

Who are the 144,000? This listing of the tribes of Israel does not exactly correlate with the twelve physical tribes. Instead, it communicates that God knows precisely which people on earth belong to him. By the AD 90s, Israel's twelve tribes no longer existed; ten tribes were dispersed when Assyria conquered the northern kingdom of Israel ([2 Kgs 17:1-41](#)). The early Christian church regarded itself symbolically as the Israel of God ([Matt 19:28](#); [Rom 2:28-29](#); [9:6-8](#); [Gal 3:29](#); [6:16](#); [Phil 3:3](#)). The 144,000 probably represent all faithful Christians (cp. [Rev 14:1-5](#); [21:12-17](#)). The list begins appropriately with Judah (the royal tribe of Jesus) but substitutes Manasseh (one of the two tribes of Joseph) for Dan. The tribe of Dan fell into idolatry ([Judg 18:14-31](#); [1 Kgs 12:25-30](#)), and early Christians regarded it as the epitome of evil.

Revelation 7:9

This vast crowd of believers ([7:14](#)) is too great to count, fulfilling God's promises to Abraham ([Gen 15:5](#); [17:4-5](#); [Rom 4:16-24](#); [Gal 3:29](#)). • White robes ([Rev 6:11](#)) and palm branches ([John 12:13](#)) are ancient symbols of victory and success, adding to the celebration that occurs after God ends the hostile world.

Revelation 7:9–17

The interlude's second vision shows heaven with an innumerable crowd rejoicing because they are secure in Christ and all tears and sorrows have ended.

Revelation 7:10

Ancient victory parades, heralding the accomplishments of conquerors, included loud chants. The shout of Salvation ("victory," "deliverance") honors God's triumph and prepares readers for his reign.

Revelation 7:11–12

The angels, elders, and four living beings all prostrated themselves before God and responded together in a sevenfold (i.e., comprehensive) doxology to recognize God's eternal nature. The doxology is preceded and followed by Amen—a powerful affirmation of God's victory.

Revelation 7:14

who died in (literally *who came out of*): See [6:9](#); [20:4](#). • the great tribulation: A time of horrible and distressing events (see [1:9](#); [2:9–10](#); [Deut 4:30–31](#); [Matt 24:21–22](#); [Acts 14:22](#)). • They have washed their robes in the blood of the Lamb: This description symbolizes Christ's redeeming death for them. • made them white: This description expresses their victory over sin and death and their acceptance by God into eternal life.

Revelation 7:15

serve him day and night: Service to God is the continual duty of Christians. • God's Temple symbolizes his presence (also [11:19](#); cp. [21:22](#)).

Revelation 7:16–17

For desert-dwellers, life-giving water and relief from the scorching sun represent paradise (see also [21:6](#); [22:1, 17](#); [Ps 23:1–2](#); [Ezek 47:1–12](#); [John](#)

[7:37–38](#)). • on the throne (literally *on the center of the throne*): The Lamb is closely identified with God. • Christ's designation as the Shepherd of God's people (cp. [Ps 23](#); [Matt 15:24](#); [John 10:3, 11, 14](#); [Heb 13:20](#); [1 Pet 2:25](#)) means that he protects and provides for the sheep, bringing hope and salvation to his people (see [Ezek 34:11–16, 23–24](#)).

Revelation 8:1

The opening of the seventh seal concludes the first act and dramatically initiates silence, which suggests the mystery of God in his dealings with the world ([10:4](#); [1 Kgs 19:11–12](#)). Perhaps the mysterious silence here is analogous to God's rest on the seventh day of creation ([Gen 2:1–3](#); see also [Heb 4:1–11](#)). • half an hour: This brief hush precedes the unfolding of the second act of divine judgment when God will answer the prayers of his people.

Revelation 8:2

The dramatic sounding of trumpets by angels heralds an approaching end (see [Isa 27:13](#); [Zech 9:14](#); [Matt 24:31](#); [1 Cor 15:52](#); [1 Thes 4:16](#)).

Revelation 8:2–6

This scene of preparation in heaven introduces the seven trumpets of judgment and continues the theme of God's receiving and answering prayer ([5:8](#); [6:9–11](#)).

Revelation 8:2–11.19

The second cycle of judgments is structured around seven trumpets. Like the first cycle ([6:1–8:1](#)), this one contains an interlude ([10:1–11:14](#); cp. [7:1–17](#)) and ends with a glimpse of God's eternal Kingdom ([11:15–19](#); see [7:9–8:1](#)). • The trumpet judgments are reminiscent of the ten plagues of Egypt ([Exod 7:14–11:10](#)) and have the same purpose—to show the powerlessness of earthly gods (or satanic powers) and to demonstrate beyond doubt the power and sovereignty of God.

Revelation 8:3–4

The prayers of God's people ask for God's ultimate justice and judgment ([6:10–11](#); see also [5:8](#); [Ezra 9:5–6](#); [Ps 141:2](#); [Dan 9:21](#)). The mixture of incense and prayers that reaches God's presence shows that God hears their prayers (see [Rev 6:9–11](#)) and is prepared to act.

Revelation 8:5

The action of the angel, as he throws fire . . . down upon the earth, signals the dramatic beginning of God's judgment (see [Gen 19:24](#); [Exod 9:23](#); [Lev 10:2](#); [Deut 9:3](#); [2 Kgs 1:10](#)). • thunder . . . lightning . . . earthquake: These earthly portents remind us of God's power, presence, and judgment (also [Rev 11:19](#); [16:18](#); see [Exod 19:18–19](#); [1 Kgs 19:11–12](#); [Isa 29:6](#)).

Revelation 8:7

Hail and fire mixed with blood signal the destruction of plant life, as did the seventh plague on Egypt (see [Exod 9:13–35](#); [Joel 2:31](#); [Acts 2:19](#)). • all the green grass was burned: Nothing escapes God's judgment. • This vision need not be harmonized with [Rev 9:4](#) because each scene is self-contained and communicates its own message.

Revelation 8:7–12

Each of the first four trumpets affects one-third of its target (see [Ezek 9:1–4](#), [12](#); [Zech 13:8](#)). The point is not to convey an exact measurement; instead, it indicates that God's judgment on the earth is beginning but has not reached its zenith. Together, the first four trumpets form a unified message of judgment on the whole physical world (as with [Rev 6:1–8](#)).

Revelation 8:8–9

water . . . became blood: This judgment is similar to the first plague on Egypt (see [Exod 7:14–25](#); [Ps 78:44](#)). • The mountain of fire suggests something similar to the eruption of Mount Vesuvius in AD 79 that brought bloody destruction to ships and sea life (see Pliny the Younger, *Letters* 6.16.1–22).

Revelation 8:10–11

The star named Bitterness (literally *wormwood*, a shrubby plant yielding a bitter extract) is symbolic rather than physical. Bitter water is connected with judgment from early in Israel's national experience ([Exod 15:22–26](#); [Num 5:18](#); [Jer 9:13–16](#); [23:15](#)). The message is that wide-scale judgment has begun.

Revelation 8:12

the fourth angel: On the fourth day of creation, God made the sun . . . the moon, and . . . the stars ([Gen 1:14–19](#)). • the day was dark: This judgment replicates the ninth plague in Egypt ([Exod 10:21–23](#)).

Revelation 8:13

The ancients regarded the eagle as a symbolic messenger of God (see *4 Ezra* 11:7–8; *2 Baruch* 77:19–26). • Terror, terror, terror: A threefold announcement would be recognized as a message from God (see [Acts 10:16](#)). • The terror (Greek *ouai*) that sounded like an eagle's screech was directed against humans of this world who were not among God's faithful people ([Rev 6:10](#); [9:4](#), [20](#)).

Revelation 9:1–12

The fifth . . . trumpet, the first of the three terrors ([8:13](#)), brings the judgment of locusts from the bottomless pit, a place of horror. Ancient cultures viewed the oceanic depths, or the "abyss," as a dwelling place of demonic forces (see study note on *Gen* 1:2).

Revelation 9:1–21

The fifth and sixth trumpets demonstrate how God's judgment affects the people of the world and detail how futile it is to resist God. While these judgments should lead to repentance, they do not. Sin has such control over people that they choose to worship the evil forces that torture and murder them rather than repent and turn to God.

Revelation 9:2

The smoke from the pit turned the sky dark, as in the plague on Egypt ([Exod 10:21-29](#); see [Matt 27:45](#)).

Revelation 9:3-4

The locusts . . . from the smoke with their power to sting like scorpions are fiercer than those of the Egyptian plague (see [Exod 10:14-15](#)). Rather than eating plants, these locusts are like stinging scorpions that viciously attack people. Only people without the seal of God (see [Rev 7:1-8](#)) receive this painful judgment. While the stings cause painful torture, they are not life-threatening ([9:5-6](#)).

Revelation 9:5

torture them for five months: This time period is a symbolically complete number based on the fingers on a hand. It is also the normal life span of locusts, suggesting that their entire purpose was to torture people.

Revelation 9:7-10

While some see these locusts as symbolic of attack helicopters, missiles, or other modern armaments, they come from the “bottomless pit” rather than from human engineering. The description of these creatures, derived from the physical appearance of locusts, is intended to cause revulsion and terror. • Their gold crowns indicate that their torment dominates much of the earth.

Revelation 9:11

The king of the locusts is identified in three ways: (1) as the angel from the bottomless pit (probably different from the fallen star, [9:1](#), who unlocked the abyss rather than coming from it); (2) as Abaddon (“destruction”), often paired with death (see [Job 28:22](#); [Ps 88:11](#)); and (3) as Apollyon—the Destroyer (see [1 Cor 10:10](#)). • Although John makes no direct connection between the devil and this king of the locusts, the prince of demons is linked with Satan in the Gospels ([Mark 3:22-26](#); see [Matt 12:24-27](#); [Luke 11:15-18](#)). The New Testament also identifies the devil as the prince of this world

([John 12:31](#); [14:30](#); [16:11](#)) and as the prince of the power of the air ([Eph 2:2](#)), so he probably represents Satan. There is also a connection with the Roman emperor Domitian, whose patron god Apollo was symbolized by the locust.

Revelation 9:13-14

The four horns of the gold altar (see [8:3](#)) are introduced with the sixth trumpet blast. Many excavations have uncovered altars with pointed horns at their four corners (see study note on [Exod 27:2](#)). • The voice carries the authority of God in the command to release the four angels. • These angels have been bound, suggesting their evil nature (cp. [Rev 20:2](#); [1 Enoch 10](#); contrast [Rev 7:1](#)). Their location at the great Euphrates River probably refers to Assyria and Babylon, empires that had devastated the kingdoms of Israel and Judah and thus were symbols of destruction (see [2 Kgs 17:22-24](#); [25:1-11](#)).

Revelation 9:15

hour and day and month and year: The fourfold time designation for releasing the four angels confirms that even evil forces must observe God’s timing.

Revelation 9:16

The relationship of the four angels to their army is not clear. • 200 million: This figure represents an innumerable multitude. Even at its greatest strength, the ancient Roman army with twenty-one legions numbered only about 126,000 soldiers. It is unproductive to use this number in attempting to identify any specific country with such an overwhelming destructive force.

Revelation 9:17-19

The riders had armor in colors that matched the plagues of their horses, with red for fire, blue for smoke, and yellow for sulfur—all of which are signs of judgment in Scripture (see [14:10-11](#); [19:20](#); [Gen 19:24-28](#); [Ps 11:6](#); [Ezek 38:22](#); [Luke 17:29](#)). • The horses are reminiscent of the terrifying monsters of Greek tales pictured on ancient buildings and

celebrated in ancient dramas. • One-third: See study note on Rev 8:7–12.

Revelation 9:20–21

Even when humans are faced with plagues and death, repentance is not automatic. People tend to continue in their evil deeds and to worship demons and idols—things that belong to the created order—rather than worshiping the Creator (see [13:4](#); [14:9–10](#); [Rom 1:25](#); [1 Cor 8:4](#); [10:19–22](#)). • murders . . . witchcraft . . . immorality . . . thefts: What people worship parallels the ways in which they live (see [Rev 21:8](#); [22:15](#); [Rom 1:23](#), [29–32](#)). • Revelation portrays the extent to which depravity controls unbelievers. It is not logical for people to worship powers and beings that torture and kill them; the powers of sin and rebellion against God are deceptively captivating.

Revelation 10:1

another mighty angel (see [5:2](#); [7:2](#); cp. [1:12–16](#)): This angel appears similar to the huge bronze Colossus that stood as a symbol of human power in the harbor of Rhodes for several decades before it was toppled by an earthquake in the late 200s BC. The statue still lay broken at the time that John wrote Revelation. It was about 100 feet tall and represented the sun god, Helios. The angel was surrounded by a cloud, suggesting that he dwarfed the Rhodes statue and, by implication, all idols. The rainbow over his head is a reminder that the enthroned God is encircled by a rainbow ([4:3](#)), a biblical symbol of God's covenant with humanity ([Gen 9:8–17](#)).

Revelation 10:1–11:14

This interlude between the sixth and seventh trumpets is divided into two parts: (1) the seven thunders and the small scroll ([10:1–11](#)), and (2) the two witnesses ([11:1–13](#)). The interlude ends with the announcement that the second terror is finished ([11:14](#)).

Revelation 10:2–3

Although the scroll is small, it is not unimportant. It reveals a small yet critical part of God's purposes in

events still to come before eternity begins. • he gave a great shout: Cp. [Job 37:2–5](#); [Ps 18:13](#); [29:3–4](#).

Revelation 10:4

Revelation reveals God's intentions in the world without eliminating the mystery of God's ways. The martyrs did not receive an immediate answer to their cries ([6:10](#)), the meaning of the seventh seal is cloaked in silence ([8:1](#)), and here the seven thunders are kept secret (cp. [Dan 12:9](#)).

Revelation 10:5–6

While raising one's right hand is common in taking an oath today, it is rare in biblical literature (cp. [Gen 14:22](#); [24:9](#); [Dan 12:7](#)). • When making an oath, Jews were very careful not to swear lightly by God's name (see [Exod 20:7](#)). Jesus also rebuked insincere oath-taking (see [Matt 5:33–37](#); [23:16–22](#)). When God swore an oath, he did so in his own name as the highest possible point of reference (see [Gen 22:16](#); [Ps 89:35–36](#); [Jer 22:5](#); [Heb 6:13–18](#)).

Revelation 10:7

angel blows his trumpet: See [1 Cor 15:51–54](#); [1 Thes 4:16](#). • God's mysterious plan for the world is no surprise; the prophets who served God in the past warned that the day of the Lord would come (see [Joel 2:1–3](#), [10–11](#); [Amos 5:18–20](#); [Zeph 1:14–18](#)).

Revelation 10:8–10

As in Ezekiel's experience, the scroll tasted sweet in the mouth ([Ezek 3:1–3](#); see [Jer 15:16](#); see also [Pss 19:10](#); [119:103](#)). The experiences yet to come for God's people would be sweet, including the victory of God's plan and the vindication of his people. John's sour . . . stomach resembles the effects of Ezekiel's hard message for Israel ([Ezek 3:8–9](#)). The process of bringing God's plan to fruition involves hardship.

Revelation 10:11

Unlike Ezekiel, who prophesied for Israel alone, John must prophesy . . . about (or *against*) all the people of the world. There is debate whether “about” or “against” is the best translation; “about” allows for both promise and judgment (see both in [21:24-27](#)).

Revelation 11:1

The instructions to measure the Temple are reminiscent of Ezekiel’s visions (see [Ezek 40-42; 43:13-17](#)). The Jerusalem Temple was destroyed by the Romans in AD 70; these details symbolize God’s precise knowledge of and care for his people who belong to him (cp. [Rev 7:2-4; Zech 2:1-5](#)).

Revelation 11:1-13

This section pictures the willful rejection of God’s continuing call for repentance. The many attempts to silence his witnesses ultimately fail, and God triumphs. • Many attempts have been made to identify the two witnesses of this chapter. Moses and Elijah, who appeared with Jesus at the transfiguration ([Matt 17:3; Mark 9:4; Luke 9:30](#)), are likely candidates (see [Rev 11:6](#)); they represent the law and the prophets. Others have suggested Enoch and Elijah because they did not die (see [Gen 5:21-24; 2 Kgs 2:11-12](#)). Other possibilities include Peter and Paul, or James and John. More important than their identities is their role of confirming God’s message by the testimony of “two or three witnesses” (see [Deut 17:6](#)). God provides a twofold witness to the world about the impending judgment, making it clear that his word is certain to be fulfilled ([Deut 19:15; Matt 18:15-16](#)).

Revelation 11:2-3

The outer courtyard in the Jerusalem Temple, outside the stone warning fence, was regarded as the place for the Gentile nations. John makes a clear distinction between the people God recognizes and those he does not. • The 42 months and 1,260 days refer to a period of three and a half years, or a broken seven (see study notes on [Dan 7:24-25; 8:26; 9:24-27](#)). John repeatedly uses these time designations in Revelation when persecution is evident and evil appears to dominate the world.

God’s people will be secure in him (see study note on [Rev 11:1](#)) even though God allows evil forces to persecute them (see [13:7; Mark 10:30](#)).

Revelation 11:3

During the period of persecution, God will not abandon the world but will send his two witnesses to proclaim the coming judgment, just as God sent Jonah to Nineveh ([Jon 1:2; 4:11](#)). • Clothing made of burlap was symbolic of mourning or repentance (see [Gen 37:34; 2 Sam 3:31; Neh 9:1; Esth 4:1; Jon 3:6](#)).

Revelation 11:4

two olive trees and . . . two lampstands: See study note on [1:12](#); see also [Exod 25:31-40; Zech 4:2-6](#).

Revelation 11:5

In one of the psalms, God is portrayed with fire coming from his mouth, a picture of judgment on his enemies ([Ps 18:8](#); see also [2 Sam 22:9](#)). Cp. Elijah, [2 Kgs 1:1-15](#).

Revelation 11:6

These two witnesses were given power to stop the rain and bring down plagues, as were Elijah (see [1 Kgs 17:1; 18:41-46](#)) and Moses (see [Exod 7:14-24; 8:1-11:10](#)).

Revelation 11:7-8

When the witnesses finish their testimony, the scene changes dramatically. The beast (cp. [13:1](#)) is introduced for the first time; it is associated with the bottomless pit. Like all enemies of God, the beast engages in war against God’s witnesses, and he kills them.

Revelation 11:8

their bodies will lie in the main street: Evil is so vindictive that it even desecrates the dead. • Jerusalem (literally *the great city*): The designation

“the great city” would have immediately suggested Rome to early readers ([16:19](#); [17:18](#); [18:10](#), [16](#), [18–19](#), [21](#)). But John also describes it as the city where their Lord was crucified as well as Sodom and Egypt—all places that were hostile to God and his people (see also [17:5](#), [9](#)). • where their Lord was crucified: There is a direct connection between how the Lord was treated by evil forces and the experience of persecuted Christians (see [Acts 9:5](#)).

Revelation 11:9

Leaving people’s bodies out for public display was a way to dishonor them after their death (see [1 Sam 31:10](#); the usual Roman custom was to leave bodies hanging after crucifixion). • peoples, tribes, languages, and nations: All the peoples of the world are represented in this exhibition.

Revelation 11:10

All the people . . . will gloat and celebrate: God’s enemies despise and reject his messengers.

Revelation 11:11

The death of the two witnesses is not the end of their ministry. God was not defeated in the death of Jesus and he will not be defeated in the slaughter of his witnesses. The God of the resurrection breathed life into the dead so that they stood up (see [Ezek 37:3–5](#), [10](#)), leaving no doubt about God’s power. • Terror struck: It is a fearful experience for sinful humans to face the power of the living God (see [Heb 10:31](#)).

Revelation 11:12

they rose to heaven in a cloud: The event is reminiscent of the ascent of Jesus (see [Acts 1:9](#)) and others (see [2 Kgs 2:11–12](#); [1 Thes 4:17](#)).

Revelation 11:13

An earthquake often accompanies key moments in biblical history (see [Exod 19:18](#); [1 Kgs 19:11–12](#); [Matt 27:51](#)). • Seven thousand: The number who died shows God’s involvement in judgment (contrast [1 Kgs 19:18](#)). • everyone else . . . gave

glory to the God of heaven: Those who survived the earthquake were forced to acknowledge God’s power and sovereignty over the world (see [Phil 2:9–11](#)).

Revelation 11:15

Loud voices in the court of heaven sing a victory hymn; the earth has been transformed into the realm of our Lord and his Christ, who is enthroned as king forever.

Revelation 11:15–19

The seventh trumpet (“the third terror,” [11:14](#); see also [9:12](#)) presents a scene of final judgment and the eternal Kingdom. As in [7:9–17](#), this scene provides a dramatic window into the ultimate Christian hope with God. In the midst of a picture of judgment, the reader is reminded of eternity with God.

Revelation 11:16–18

The twenty-four elders, representing the people of God, confirm God’s victorious enthronement (see study note on 4:4). Their worship acknowledges God’s sovereign rule as the Almighty (see [4:10–11](#); [5:8–10](#)).

Revelation 11:17

The thanksgiving prayer describes God as the one who is and who always was; the description “is still to come” (see [1:4](#), [8](#)) no longer applies, because in this scene eternity has come and God has begun to reign.

Revelation 11:18

The nations were filled with wrath when they refused to do as God commanded (see [Ps 2](#)). But things will now be different because God’s wrath has come. God will reward his holy people (see [Rev 22:12](#)) with new life as his children (see [John 1:12](#); [20:31](#)). • fear your name: God’s name implies his nature; fearing God’s name means accepting who he is (see “Fear of the Lord” Theme Note). • The end of the age will be the time to destroy those who

have not accepted God's love (see [John 3:16-20](#)). They will go into the lake of fire ([Rev 20:15](#)). This doom of God's enemies is the third and final terror ([11:14](#)).

Revelation 11:19

This verse provides a dramatic conclusion to the first half of Revelation and a link to the second half.

- In this scene, the Temple and the Ark are symbols of God's presence; the earthly Ark was the copy of the design of the Ark in heaven (see [Exod 25:40](#); [Heb 8:5](#)).

Revelation 12:1

The number twelve suggests that the woman represents God's people (cp. [12:15-17](#); see [Jer 2:32](#); [2 Cor 11:2](#); [Eph 5:32](#)), from whom came the Messiah. This woman is marked by God's glory in contrast with the prostitute (see [Rev 17:1-6](#)), who is destined for destruction.

Revelation 12:1-17

Satan (pictured as a dragon) plots to challenge God's purposes but is thwarted. Having failed in direct confrontation with God and Christ, he attempts to attack God's people. Three brief scenes present an overview of the story ([12:1-6](#)), followed by elaborations of the war in heaven ([12:7-9](#)) and the war on earth ([12:13-17](#)).

Revelation 12:1-14:20

The people of God, portrayed as a woman who brings forth the Messiah, are under attack by the devil even though he has already been defeated ([12:1-17](#)). With his two minions, the beast and the false prophet, Satan attempts to continue controlling the world ([13:1-18](#)) before the final confrontation with the Lord ([14:1-20](#)).

Revelation 12:2

The symbolic woman going through the agony of labor portrays Christ's birth, reflecting the biblical theme of Israel's trauma while waiting to be

delivered (see [Isa 26:16-18](#); [Jer 4:31](#); [Mic 4:9-10](#); [John 16:21](#)).

Revelation 12:3-4

The large red dragon represents Satan (see [12:9](#)). • seven heads and ten horns: The numbers represent a mixture of divine and created powers (see [17:7-14](#)). • The historic battle between evil and the people of God is staged in cosmic dimensions (see [Gen 3:1-7](#), [14-15](#); [Job 1:9-12](#)). • Herod's desire to kill Jesus embodied Satan's attempt to devour her baby after it was born (see [Matt 2:7-8](#), [16](#)).

Revelation 12:5

Jesus was the son who was to rule all nations (see [Luke 1:31-33](#); [2:30-32](#); cp. [Ps 2:6-12](#)). • Although Jesus was killed by agents of the devil, he was snatched away from the dragon and raised from the dead ([Matt 28:6](#); [Mark 10:33-34](#); [16:6](#); [1 Cor 15:3-4](#)). Jesus' entire life on earth, from his birth to his death and resurrection, is compressed into this scene. • caught up to God and to his throne: See [Acts 1:9-11](#).

Revelation 12:6

Like the people of Israel who were spiritually refined in the wilderness (see [Hos 2:14-15](#); [Acts 7:38-45](#)) and in exile (see [Isa 5:13](#); [Ezek 12:1-3](#)), the Christian church must face its own wilderness. Revelation presents messages of endurance and perseverance in the face of trouble and shows that God provides places of refuge and avenues of escape for his people (cp. [1 Cor 10:13](#)). 1,260 days: See study note on Rev 11:2-3.

Revelation 12:7-9

This scene clarifies the dragon's identity and power. • God dispatches Michael, the warrior archangel (see [Dan 12:1](#); [Jude 1:9](#)), to confront the dragon and his angels. God does not have to engage in the battle himself (see [Matt 26:53](#)), and Satan is defeated.

Revelation 12:10–11

Satan's defeat is encouraging for Christians who, like the recipients of Revelation, are not afraid to die (see [John 12:24–26](#)).

Revelation 12:13

When the dragon realized: The scene picks up from [12:9](#).

Revelation 12:14

two wings . . . of a great eagle (see [Exod 19:4–6](#); [Deut 32:10–11](#); [Isa 40:29–31](#)): God strengthens his people; he does not promise that they will escape persecution or death. • a time, times, and half a time: Usually understood as three and a half years (see [Rev 11:2–3](#)).

Revelation 12:15–16

John pictures Satan as Leviathan (cp. [Job 41:1](#)) trying to destroy God's people (the woman; see study note on Rev 12:1). The protective earth responds and the waters of chaos are contained, as at creation (cp. [Gen 1:2, 6–7, 9–10](#)).

Revelation 12:17

The dragon turns his hostility against the woman's children (believers) who keep God's commandments and continue in their testimony for Jesus.

Revelation 12:18

on the shore beside the sea: By contrast, the Lamb stands on the rock of Zion ([14:1](#)).

Revelation 12:18–13:18

John portrays the dragon conducting its war ([12:17](#)) through two beasts who with Satan form an evil trinity.

Revelation 13:1

The beast emerges from the sea (symbolizing evil). Like the dragon, it has seven heads and ten horns (see [12:3](#)). The crowns represent its political and military power (cp. [17:3, 7–11](#); [Dan 7:7, 19–20](#)) and indicate that Satan is the head of this beast's empire.

Revelation 13:1–10

The first beast is the second member of the evil trinity (see study note on 12:18–13:18) and should probably be identified with Roman power (see "Four World Empires" Theme Note).

Revelation 13:2

Satan makes the beast a pseudo-deity by giving it his power, throne, and authority. In the first century, Roman emperors increasingly claimed divinity.

Revelation 13:3

Satan often imitates God. Here the beast mimics the death and resurrection of Jesus. • That one of the heads had been fatally wounded but was healed has led to its identification with Nero. A tradition emerged that the emperor Nero (AD 54–68) was so evil that he either did not really die or would be reincarnated as another tyrant like Domitian (AD 81–96). In [17:9–10](#), the beast's seven heads are linked both to *seven hills* (Rome) and to *seven kings*.

Revelation 13:5

The forty-two months are the three and a half years of persecution and evil domination (see study note on 11:2–3).

Revelation 13:5–8

The four characteristics of the beast are that he (1) blasphemes God, (2) has authority for a limited time, (3) makes war against God's people, and (4) rules the world. But God is in control.

Revelation 13:7

The beast's authority extends over all the people of the world.

Revelation 13:8

Those who worshiped the beast receive its mark ([13:15-17](#)) and are not listed in the Book of Life (see [20:12](#)).

Revelation 13:9-10

The scene ([13:1-10](#)) ends with a dramatic conclusion patterned on [Jer 15:2](#); [43:11](#). Anyone with ears to hear must pay attention, because judgment is coming (cp. [Rev 2:7](#), [11](#), [17](#)).

Revelation 13:10

God's holy people are summoned to endure and remain faithful while experiencing temporary persecution.

Revelation 13:11

The beast is portrayed as a lamb, the same symbol used to represent Christ (see [5:6-13](#); [7:9-17](#); [14:1-4](#)), but this lamb spoke like a dragon. The image is of a fraudulent messiah. • The two horns might stand for two emperors, perhaps Nero and Domitian.

Revelation 13:11-18

another beast: This second beast, the third member of the evil trinity (see study note on [12:18-13:18](#)), is later called the "false prophet" ([16:13](#)). As a high priest of false religion, he leads the world into worshipping the first beast and the dragon (see also [16:13-14](#)).

Revelation 13:12

he required . . . people to worship the first beast: Imperial Rome demanded worship of the emperor Domitian. • whose fatal wound had been healed: This description might refer to Domitian, who was

viewed as the reincarnation of Nero (see study note on [13:3](#)). The image is a picture of the constant reemergence of evil, particularly in the latter days (see study note on [17:8](#)).

Revelation 13:12-15

The second beast derives its power from the first beast, which in turn answers to the dragon ([13:4](#)).

Revelation 13:13-15

In New Testament times, false prophets astounded people with reports of divine visitations and of idols speaking for the gods they represented (see [Acts 16:16-18](#); [1 Cor 12:2-3](#)). Such practices involved worship of demons (see [1 Cor 10:20-21](#)) and were epitomized in the Roman emperor cult. Those who refused to conform were put to death.

Revelation 13:14-15

he was allowed. . . . He was then permitted: God never relinquishes ultimate authority. These creatures of evil have been allowed to rebel against God, but they are not in control.

Revelation 13:16-17

small and great, rich and poor, free and slave: All humanity is required to accept the beast's evil mark of ownership (see [14:9](#), [11](#); [19:20](#); [20:4](#)), a precondition for all commerce (the right to buy or sell). The text does not explicitly tell us what the mark is or looks like. • On the right hand or on the forehead suggests the branding of slaves—the beast owns them. • the number representing his name: In both Hebrew and Greek, letters of the alphabet represent numbers, which gave names a numerical value ([13:18](#)).

Revelation 13:18

Wisdom is needed: John is giving a clue to help his readers solve the meaning of the beast's number. • of a man: John hides the man's identity, perhaps because revealing the name would place him and his readers in danger (cp. use of Babylon as a symbol for Rome, [17:9](#)). • The number 666

represents supernatural evil (see “Symbolic Numbers” Theme Note). John might have used the transliteration *Caesar Neron* (a Hebrew spelling of the name) to arrive at the number 666. Later scribes, who spoke Greek but not Hebrew, corrected the number to 616 in some manuscripts, probably to match the name’s numerical value in Greek.

Revelation 14:1

standing: See [5:6](#); study note on 12:18. • 144,000: God’s righteous remnant (see study note on 7:4–8). • The brand on their foreheads (contrast [13:16–17](#)) is the name of both the Lamb and his Father, reflecting the union of Jesus and the Father (see [John 5:20–23](#); [14:5–10](#); [17:22](#)).

Revelation 14:1–5

The true Lamb and his followers starkly contrast with the evil trinity.

Revelation 14:2–3

This great choir sang a ... new song that only those who had been redeemed from the earth could learn. These people had died and were already with the Lord, which might explain why John did not include the content of their refrain for readers still in the battle of life (cp. [2 Cor 12:4](#)).

Revelation 14:4–5

These warriors were ritually pure (unpolluted) and morally without blame. • They have kept themselves as pure as virgins: Referring to men as *virgins* is a metaphor for the faithfulness of God’s people. The image might refer to the church as the virgin bride of Christ (see [2 Cor 11:2](#); [Eph 5:25–27](#)); it also suggests that the church constitutes soldiers in a holy war that are required to keep themselves chaste (see [Deut 23:9–10](#); [1 Sam 21:5](#)). • These faithful people are a special offering (literally *firstfruits*; see [Exod 13:14–16](#); [23:19](#); [Lev 23:9–14](#); [Num 3:40–51](#); [18:15–20](#); [Luke 2:22–24](#)) who have been purchased for God. • They have told no lies: John teaches that liars will never enter heaven ([Rev 21:8](#), [27](#); [22:15](#); see also [John 8:44](#)). The followers

of Jesus speak and live the truth (see also [John 8:32](#); [14:6](#)).

Revelation 14:6–7

The first angel proclaims the eternal Good News, which includes the message that God will sit as judge—the end is near, so this message provides a last-chance summons to repentance.

Revelation 14:6–13

Three angels are flying through the sky with messages from God.

Revelation 14:8

Babylon is probably a cryptic designation for Rome (see [16:19](#); [17:5–9](#)); it represents earthly power and corruption. The coming of God as judge ([14:7](#)) includes the end of earthly powers.

Revelation 14:9–11

The third angel announces God’s judgment ([14:7](#)) on the counterfeit worship of the beast and his statue (see [13:12–18](#); [19:20](#); [20:4](#)). God’s response to the rebellion against his reign is anger or wrath, pictured as a cup of bitter wine (see ch [16](#); [19:15](#)). • fire and burning sulfur ... smoke: This description of judgment (see also [19:20](#); [20:10](#), [14–15](#)) echoes God’s judgment of Sodom and Gomorrah ([Gen 18:16–19:28](#)). • Those condemned to a fiery end will suffer in the presence of the holy angels and the Lamb (cp. [Luke 16:22–24](#)).

Revelation 14:12

The threat of persecution and death was very real to the Christians first reading this letter, so John calls God’s people to obedience and faithfulness (see [2:10](#); [3:10](#); [12:17](#); [13:10](#)).

Revelation 14:13

A dramatic voice from heaven once again instructs John to write (see [1:11](#), [19](#); [21:5](#); cp. [10:4](#)). •

Blessed are those who die in the Lord: God desires that those who endure persecution be with him and enjoy his blessings and rest. • The mention of hard work and good deeds in connection with eternal reward foreshadows the assigning of rewards based on works ([20:12](#)).

Revelation 14:14

the Son of Man: Or *like a son of man*; see study note on 1:13. • A gold crown is a symbol of status or power, clearly distinguishing Jesus from the angels (see [4:4](#); [6:2](#); [9:7](#); [12:3](#); [13:1](#)). • The sharp sickle is symbolic of God's harvest of judgment (see [14:17-18](#); see also [Jer 51:33](#); [Hos 6:11](#); [Mic 4:12-13](#)).

Revelation 14:14-20

Two brief scenes portray God's judgment.

Revelation 14:15-18

The Temple and the altar represent God's presence (see [9:13](#); [11:19](#); [16:7](#)).

Revelation 14:18-20

The ripe . . . grapes (see [Amos 8:2](#)) that are trampled in the winepress emphasize God's power to judge (see [Rev 19:15](#); [Joel 3:13](#)). • Winepresses were built outside cities and towns; here, the city is Jerusalem. The bloody river of death stretched about 180 miles. God's enemies stand no chance when the Son of Man comes in judgment. The carnage here is closely linked with the final battle in [Rev 19:17-21](#); God is just and fair in giving people exactly what they deserve (see [16:5-7](#)).

Revelation 15:1

This cycle of seven last plagues ([15:1-16:21](#)) brings God's wrath against his enemies to completion (see [16:17](#); [Amos 1-2](#); [Rom 1:18-2:16](#)). Revelation returns later to the subjects of God's wrath ([Rev 19:15-21](#)).

Revelation 15:1-16:21

The third and final cycle of seven judgments (see study note on 6:1-16:21) is introduced with a vision of God's victorious people singing a hymn of praise ([15:2-4](#)). Then a scene of the Temple is presented ([15:5-8](#)), from which angels emerge bearing the bowls of God's judgment upon the earth ([16:1-21](#)).

Revelation 15:2

The glass sea mixed with fire symbolizes victory through testing. Those who had been victorious over the beast (see [13:1-8](#), [15-18](#)) hold harps that represent ultimate peace. Their place on the *glass sea* (cp. [4:6](#)) symbolizes their endurance in the *fire* of persecution (cp. [Ps 66:12](#); [Isa 43:2](#); [Dan 3:8-30](#)).

Revelation 15:3

The Lord God, the Almighty (see also [1:8](#); [4:8](#); [11:17](#); [16:7](#); [19:6](#); [21:22](#)): For persecuted Christians, the message that God is all-powerful provides great comfort and security. • The truth that God is also just and true is the foundation of human integrity in the midst of a confused, unjust, and dishonest world. • God is the supreme, universal King of the nations, not a localized deity attached to one nation or to a human monarch with limited authority.

Revelation 15:3-4

The song of Moses and the Lamb signifies that God's will is united in the old and new covenants.

Revelation 15:4

Who will not fear ... and glorify your name? This rhetorical question (cp. [Jer 10:7](#)) assumes that only a fool would fail to do so (cp. [Rev 14:7](#); [16:9](#); see [Pss 14:1](#); [53:1](#)). • God alone is holy: See [Rev 16:5](#); [Lev 11:44](#); [1 Pet 1:16](#). God's holiness is the basis for our worship and salvation. • All nations will . . . worship: Some will be forced to acknowledge God (cp. [Phil 2:10-11](#)), but all will recognize that God's deeds and judgments have been revealed and are righteous and just.

Revelation 15:5-6

God's Tabernacle implies God's presence (see [John 1:14](#)); even the plagues have their source in God's presence. Christ's sacrifice ([Matt 27:51](#); [Mark 15:38](#); [Heb 6:19-20](#); [10:19-20](#)) removed the veil between God and humanity (see [Exod 26:31-35](#); [Lev 16](#)). Now those who do not belong to Christ experience the full force of God's presence (see [Rev 20:11-15](#); [Isa 13:4-12](#); [Zeph 2:1-3](#); [Mal 3:2-3](#)). • white linen: Linen, a symbol of purity, was also worn by the priests when performing their duties (see [Exod 28:39-43](#); [Lev 16:4, 23](#); see also [Ezek 9:2-3](#); [Dan 12:6-7](#)). The function of these angels is not intercession; they are agents of judgment. The linen therefore represents the purity and justice of God's judgment. • The gold sashes across their chests probably symbolize their divine mission as ministers of justice on God's behalf (cp. [Rev 1:13](#)).

Revelation 15:7

the four living beings: See [4:6-8](#). • a gold bowl: These bowls are probably like the offering pans that were used in ancient worship (see [Exod 37:16](#)).

Revelation 15:8

The Temple was filled with smoke as a symbol of God's glory and power ([Isa 6:4](#); see [Exod 19:16-18](#); [40:34-35](#); [1 Kgs 8:10-13](#)).

Revelation 16:1

The mighty voice probably belongs to God (also in [6:6](#); [9:13](#); [16:17](#); [18:4](#); [19:5](#); see [Isa 66:6](#)).

Revelation 16:1-21

These seven bowls filled with God's wrath represent the final judgments on the world; with the seventh bowl, "It is finished!" is shouted from God's throne ([16:17](#); cp. [John 19:30](#)).

Revelation 16:2

The malignant sores are reminiscent of the sixth plague of Egypt ([Exod 9:9-11](#)). • mark of the beast: See [Rev 13:13-17](#); [14:9-10](#).

Revelation 16:3-4

The plagues of the second and third bowls are similar to the first plague of Egypt ([Exod 7:17-21](#)). Perhaps John had in mind that much of Rome's food and wealth came by sea. After Julius Caesar rid the sea of pirates, shipping became Rome's lifeblood. Its end would mean economic death for the empire (see [Rev 18:17-19](#)).

Revelation 16:5-6

the angel who had authority over all water: Angels and archangels are portrayed as having special roles in the hierarchy of heaven (see [Dan 8:16](#); [9:21](#); [10:13, 21](#); [12:1](#); [Luke 1:19, 26](#); see also [1 Enoch 66:1-2](#)). This angel confirms these judgments as coming from God, who is both just and holy.

Revelation 16:6

Punishment of God's enemies is a just reward because they killed God's holy people and prophets. Because they have shed . . . blood, they must drink . . . blood. The principle of *lex talionis* (the law of retribution), the basis of Roman and Jewish jurisprudence, means that God is completely just in judging and rewarding people on the basis of what they have done (see [2:23](#); [11:18](#); [14:13](#); [18:6](#); [20:12, 13](#); [22:12](#)).

Revelation 16:7

I heard a voice from the altar: The antiphonal response to the angel's proclamation ([16:5-6](#)) affirms God's authority and justice. This doxology in the midst of judgment reminds persecuted Christians that God truly cares about his suffering servants and fulfills his own purpose in everything.

Revelation 16:8-9

The fourth . . . bowl is unlike any of the plagues of Egypt or the earlier seals or trumpets. • Everyone was burned: Contrast [7:16](#). Yet the recipients of this judgment refused to repent or give God glory (see [9:20-21](#); [16:11](#); cp. [14:6-7](#)); they even cursed the name of God.

Revelation 16:10-11

the throne of the beast: John might be alluding to Rome, the political power of his time. Built on seven hills ([17:9](#)), Rome's empire spanned the sea ([13:1](#)) and ruled the world ([13:7](#)). • plunged into darkness: Similar to the ninth plague of Egypt ([Exod 10:22](#)) and to the fourth trumpet ([Rev 8:12](#)). • ground their teeth [literally *gnawed their tongues*] ... cursed the God of heaven: Both pain and hostility motivated these responses to punishment (cp. [Matt 8:12](#); [13:42](#), [50](#); [22:13](#); [24:51](#); [25:30](#); [Luke 13:28](#)).

Revelation 16:12

The Euphrates, the largest river in Mesopotamia, stood between Babylon and Israel and formed the eastern boundary of the Roman Empire. If it dried up, it would allow kings from the east to move their armies westward (cp. [9:13-16](#)). From John's perspective as an ancient Jewish writer, these armies would always be identified with Mesopotamia rather than with countries farther east such as China or India.

Revelation 16:13-14

Three agents of deceit, evil spirits in the form of frogs, represent the demonic role of the evil trinity. Although the powers of evil battle against the Lord, it is God the Almighty, not any evil power, who is in control.

Revelation 16:15

Readers are warned to look because the Lord will come as unexpectedly as a thief (see also [3:3](#); [Matt 24:43](#); [25:13](#); [1 Thes 5:2](#); [2 Pet 3:10](#)). Being ready for his coming requires preparation; those who are not prepared will not have the proper clothing and will find themselves naked (see [Matt 22:11-13](#)).

This imagery recalls the two failing churches: lifeless Sardis, which is told to "wake up" ([Rev 3:2](#)), and lukewarm Laodicea, which is advised to obtain proper clothing ([3:18](#)).

Revelation 16:16

The name Armageddon (or *Harmagedon*) is probably derived from Hebrew *har* ("mountain," "hill") plus Megiddo, which was one of the three cities fortified by Solomon along with Gezer in the south and Hazor in the north ([1 Kgs 9:15](#)). The fortress of Megiddo stood on a hill in the largest pass through the Carmel range, strategically guarding the Jezreel Valley. The city was situated on the Via Maris, the main highway between Egypt and Mesopotamia. Many armies used this route, and the site became known as a bloody battlefield. It was here, for instance, that Pharaoh Neco, on his way to fight the Assyrians, killed Josiah ([2 Kgs 23:29](#)). Armageddon thus became a symbolic term epitomizing the final conflict between God and the forces of evil.

Revelation 16:17

When the seventh . . . bowl is poured out, an unexpected event occurs. The enemies of God had assembled themselves for battle, but when the decisive moment arrives, instead of the battle comes the shout, "It is finished!" Jesus uttered these same words from the cross when he had finished his work ([John 19:30](#)). No one can ultimately fight God. Therefore, this scene pictures an end to rebellion against God. What remains are various descriptions of the end.

Revelation 16:18-20

The catastrophic events of this judgment scene recapitulate the scenes portraying the destruction of the world ([6:12-14](#); [11:13](#)). They also foreshadow the final judgment ([20:11-15](#)) when the earth will be dismantled to make way for the new creation ([21:1](#); cp. [Isa 45:2](#); [Rom 8:19-22](#)).

Revelation 16:21

Despite the severity of these plagues, the people of the world again cursed God rather than recognizing

his reason for the judgments (see [9:20](#); [16:9](#), [11](#)). • The terrible hailstorm is a reminder of the seventh plague on Egypt ([Exod 9:23–24](#)).

Revelation 17:1

One of the . . . angels of judgment addresses John and summons him to a new scene in which he sees the coming judgment of the great prostitute, who rules over many waters. Rome, located on the Tiber River, controlled the seats of power and water trade routes throughout the Mediterranean, from the British Isles to the Euphrates River.

Revelation 17:1–19:10

The great drama in this section focuses on the powers that are hostile to God and responsible for the persecution and suffering of God's people. Rome's power was captivating to many ([17:6](#)); John purposely defines Rome's sins and provides God's assessment ([17:3–18](#)) before outlining its fall ([18:1–24](#)) and heaven's response ([19:1–10](#)).

Revelation 17:2

Adultery with her is a biblical image for serving other gods (see, e.g., [Exod 34:12–16](#); [Judg 2:17](#); [Hos 2](#)). • drunk by . . . her immorality: Drunkenness in Scripture often depicts nations that indulge in wanton and immoral behavior (see [Rev 18:3](#), [9](#); [Jer 25:27](#); [51:7](#); [Lam 4:21](#); [Ezek 23:33](#)).

Revelation 17:3–4

John is carried in the Spirit into the wilderness, his way of describing a visionary experience (see [1:10](#); [4:2](#)). He sees a depiction of Rome's moral corruption and excessive luxury (see [18:12–13](#), [16](#)) that illustrates how such wealth can become an abomination to God. • The beast here is like the second figure in the evil trinity (see [13:1–4](#)). • blasphemies against God: See [13:5–6](#). • purple and scarlet: Clothing in these two colors indicated royalty and carnality, respectively. • a gold goblet: See [Jer 51:7](#).

Revelation 17:5

Using code language, John was probably referring to Rome (see [17:9](#)) as Babylon the Great, Mother of All Prostitutes. Babylon was a symbol of the idolatries and demonic obscenities of the world. As *Mother*, she had produced offspring who copied her character. Rome, like Babylon, prostituted herself to false gods and led other nations into adultery and idolatry.

Revelation 17:6

God's holy people . . . were witnesses for Jesus to the point of shedding their blood (see [16:6](#); [Heb 12:4](#)). In John's time, Rome was responsible for this persecution.

Revelation 17:7

In response to John's amazement, the angel prepares him to understand the mystery ([17:8–14](#)).

Revelation 17:8

The beast . . . was once alive but isn't now . . . will soon come up: When Domitian became emperor (AD 81–96), he was as evil as Nero (both were fierce persecutors of the church), and many thought he was the embodiment of Nero's spirit, if not Nero himself (perhaps similar to the way that John the Baptist was considered to embody Elijah's spirit; see [Mal 4:5](#); [Matt 11:14](#); [Luke 1:17](#); [John 1:21](#)). • you saw: The past tense indicates that the angel's interpretation took place after John's vision. • was once alive but isn't now: This contrasts with God, "who is, who always was, and who is still to come" ([Rev 1:4](#), [8](#)). • the bottomless pit: See study note on 9:1–12. • In contrast to God's people, the people of this world are not written in the Book of Life (see [20:11–15](#)). They will be amazed by the apparent resurrection of the beast (see study note on 17:10–11; see also [13:13–17](#)).

Revelation 17:8–11

The destruction within this vision contrasts with the destiny of the people of God in the new heaven and earth (see [21:1–4](#)).

Revelation 17:9

The seven heads of the beast represent the seven hills on which Rome was built (see study note on 16:10–11). • the woman: see [17:3–6](#).

Revelation 17:10–11

Five kings have already fallen: If these kings represent Roman emperors, and the starting point for numbering them is the switch from a republic to an empire with Augustus (29 BC–AD 14), then the fifth in line would be Nero (AD 54–68), the sixth would be Vespasian, and the seventh would be Titus. The eighth king would then be Domitian. • that was, but is no longer: Early commentators argued that Domitian was an embodiment of Nero's spirit (see study note on 17:8). • like the other seven: This apparently invincible ruler was also headed for destruction.

Revelation 17:12–13

The ten horns, symbolic of the world kingdoms that follow the beast, rule simultaneously under his direction. While these verses have caused speculation concerning a ten-nation confederacy (from the client kingdoms of Rome, to the states opposed to the Holy Roman Empire, to the European Union), these conjectures are beside the point, which is that all nations opposed to God will be defeated ([17:14](#)).

Revelation 17:14

Whatever power they amass, the beast and ten kings ([17:11–12](#)) have no hope of winning because Jesus is Lord of all lords (see [19:11–16](#)). Those God has called and chosen and who remain faithful to him will stand with him as victors.

Revelation 17:15–16

While the prostitute rules over the masses, it does not bring her victory. Instead, the beast hates and kills the great prostitute. Satan strikes even those he uses for his evil purposes.

Revelation 17:17

John provides another reminder that God is in control; God puts a plan into the minds of the enemy that will fulfill the Lord's divine purposes (e.g., [Exod 7:3](#); [35:31–35](#); [Ezra 7:27](#); [Rom 9:18, 21](#)).

Revelation 18:1

This angel derived his splendor from heaven. The word splendor is normally used for the divine presence.

Revelation 18:1–3

The angel's powerful taunt song is the first poetic response. Ancient taunt songs derided a defeated enemy (see [Isa 13:19–22](#); [34:10–17](#)). In these taunts, the fall of Babylon (or Rome; see study note on Rev 14:8) is portrayed as a traumatic event for subservient kingdoms and especially for those who had profited from her luxury. The sacking of Rome by the Goths and Visigoths (AD 400s) brought the prosperous empire to an end.

Revelation 18:1–24

This chapter contains seven poetic responses to the fall of Babylon (or Rome; see study note on 17:5).

Revelation 18:2

Babylon is fallen: See [Isa 21:9](#). Once a beautifully dressed woman (see [Rev 17:4](#)), Babylon (Rome) became a desolate den for demons and unclean birds such as vultures (cp. [Isa 13:20–22](#); [Jer 4:23–31](#); [50:39](#)).

Revelation 18:3

extravagant luxury: Rome plundered conquered nations of their wealth before God's justice fell on her.

Revelation 18:4

Do not take part in her sins: Association with the evil city could lead to being identified with it in

punishment and even involved with it in its sins (see [Gen 13:8–13](#); [19:1–29](#); cp. [Jer 51:6, 45](#)).

Revelation 18:4–8

This second poetic response (see study note on 18:1–24) is a warning from heaven to flee the doomed city.

Revelation 18:5

God remembers: His response may seem slow ([Ps 103:8](#); [145:8](#); [Joel 2:13](#); [Jon 4:2](#)), but God is not weak, and he does not forget either good or evil ([Rev 16:19](#); [Gen 19:29](#); [1 Sam 1:19](#)).

Revelation 18:6

Double her penalty: The severity of some sins required a double recompense (see [Exod 22:4, 7, 9](#); cp. [Isa 40:2](#); [Jer 16:18](#); [17:18](#)).

Revelation 18:7

I am queen: Cp. [Ezek 28:1–2](#).

Revelation 18:8

The plagues ([18:2–3](#)) are a reminder that destruction was not merely a human action; it is the Lord God who judges her. He is mighty, able to accomplish what he promises.

Revelation 18:9–10

The kings of the world lament as they mourn the loss of the luxury they had obtained from alliance with the wicked city.

Revelation 18:9–19

These three laments highlight the grief of those who profited most from the wicked city's rich lifestyle (cp. [Ezek 27](#)).

Revelation 18:10

With a terrified sense of separation and abandonment (see [18:15, 17](#)), the kings stand at a distance in a futile attempt to avoid punishment.

Revelation 18:11–17

The merchants of the world sing the second lament ([18:14](#); see study note on 18:9–19). They profited from the Roman economy ([18:12–13](#)), but their trade ceased as the great city was swiftly destroyed.

Revelation 18:12–13

This cargo list suggests the extent of the wealth Rome pillaged from the rest of its empire (cp. [Ezek 27:12–24](#)). Some of the most expensive products in the ancient world are mentioned in this indictment of ostentatious materialism and pride.

Revelation 18:13

bodies: Rome developed a huge slave market, which some historians have estimated at nearly 20% of the population.

Revelation 18:14–17

The merchants would lament the fall of Rome (see study note on 18:1–3) because it would forever end their accustomed luxuries. Material goods can be swept aside in a single moment.

Revelation 18:17–19

all the captains: Seafarers sing the third lament (see study note on 18:9–19). Their mourning focuses on the breakdown of communication and transportation. During the reign of Julius Caesar, the Mediterranean was cleared of pirates and trade blossomed under the region's Roman law enforcement. The swift loss of Roman authority would upset the system of trade.

Revelation 18:20

The laments ([18:9–19](#)) stimulate a call for heaven to rejoice. The people of God are not to grieve, because the judgment was for their sakes; they had suffered persecution from the evil forces represented by the great city.

Revelation 18:21

a boulder the size of a huge millstone: Heavy millstones, shaped for grinding olives or grain, were used throughout the ancient world. Jesus also spoke of using such stones in judgment (see [Matt 18:6](#)). The dramatically thrown boulder signified that the power of Rome was forever thrown down.

Revelation 18:21–24

The songs responding to Babylon's fall ([18:1–24](#)) conclude with a portrayal of the city's doom.

Revelation 18:23

Cp. [Jer 25:10–11](#).

Revelation 19:1–2

This scene focuses on what John heard rather than on what he saw. The first three-part praise comes from a vast crowd (cp. [7:9–10](#)).

Revelation 19:1–10

This section expands the message of the sixth song of response ([18:20](#); see study note on [18:1–24](#)), which called for rejoicing. Various groups direct praises to the Lord. The praises can be divided into two sections: thankfulness for the destruction of the evildoers ([19:1–4](#)) and thankfulness for the reward of God's people ([19:5–8](#)).

Revelation 19:2

true and just (see [15:3](#); [16:7](#)): In his righteous justice, God kept his promise of judging the great prostitute, who represents moral and spiritual corruption and persecution of God's people.

Revelation 19:3

The smoke from that city: God's people praise him once again as they see the evil city's demise (cp. [14:11](#)).

Revelation 19:4

In response to the first two praises ([19:1–3](#)), the elders and the living beings (see ch [4](#)) again prostrate themselves before the enthroned God (see [4:10](#); [5:8](#), [14](#); [7:11](#)). • Amen! See study note on [5:14](#).

Revelation 19:6–8

The focus of the final thunderous Praise the Lord! is that God reigns as the Almighty in complete supremacy (see [1:8](#); [4:8](#); [11:17](#); [15:3](#); [16:7](#), [14](#); [19:15](#); [21:22](#)).

Revelation 19:7

the wedding feast of the Lamb: This event—the wedding of the Messiah with his bride, the church (see [Isa 54:5](#); [61:10](#); [Jer 31:32](#); [Ezek 16:7–14](#); [Hos 2:16–20](#); [Mark 2:19–20](#); [2 Cor 11:2](#))—symbolizes complete victory and eternal fellowship.

Revelation 19:8

finest . . . linen: See study note on [15:5–6](#). • the good deeds of God's holy people: See [Eph 2:8–10](#); [2 Tim 3:16–17](#); [Jas 2:18–22](#).

Revelation 19:9

Blessed are those: This fourth blessing in Revelation (see [1:3](#); [14:13](#); [16:15](#)) affirms the hope of the faithful. • who are invited: God is in control and determines who will participate. • wedding feast (cp. [19:17](#)): Jesus often used meals to explain the Kingdom ([Matt 22:1–13](#); [Luke 14:7–24](#)), and he ordained a meal for the church ([Mark 14:22–25](#); [1 Cor 11:23–26](#)). • These are true words: This oath asserts the reliability of the message.

Revelation 19:10

The angel issues a stern warning against misdirected worship (cp. [22:8-9](#)).

Revelation 19:11

The rider is both a judge and a righteous warrior (see [Isa 11:1-5](#)). He is named Faithful and True: He embodies God's authenticity and reliability (see [Rev 19:2](#); [21:5-6](#)).

Revelation 19:11-16

Then I saw: John describes a new vision of Jesus Christ as the holy warrior and conquering King (see [14:1](#); see also [Exod 15:1-7](#); [Pss 24:8](#); [78:49-50](#); [Isa 59:16-17](#)).

Revelation 19:11-20:15

The drama moves into its climactic scenes: God's enemies are defeated and punished in two episodes ([19:11-21](#); [20:7-10](#)). Meanwhile, the faithful experience a 1,000-year resurrection ([20:1-6](#)) followed by the final judgment ([20:11-15](#)).

Revelation 19:12

His eyes were like flames of fire: See [1:14-16](#); [Dan 10:6](#). • Christ, wearing many crowns, is contrasted with the dragon, whose seven heads were each crowned (see [Rev 12:3](#)).

Revelation 19:13

He wore a robe dipped in blood: This description may refer to (1) the blood of Christ's enemies, signifying his total victory ([Isa 63:2-4](#)); or (2) Christ's sacrificial death for humanity ([Rev 1:7](#)). • The Word of God is John's distinctive designation for Jesus (see [John 1:1, 14](#)).

Revelation 19:14

Christ's armies of heaven, dressed in victorious white and riding on white horses, contrast with the locust forces of the abyss ([9:3-11](#)), the three frog-like evil spirits ([16:13](#)), and the defeated armies at Armageddon ([16:16](#); see also [19:19](#)).

Revelation 19:15

From his mouth . . . a sharp sword: See [1:16](#); [Heb 4:12](#); see also [Isa 49:2](#); [2 Thes 2:8](#). • The iron rod represents Christ's power as ruler and as supreme shepherd (see [Pss 2:9](#); [23:4](#)). • God, the Almighty: See [Rev 1:8](#); [4:8](#); [11:17](#); [16:7, 14](#); [21:22](#). • His fierce wrath will crush his enemies like grapes in a winepress ([Isa 63:2-4](#)).

Revelation 19:16

King . . . and Lord: See [1:5](#); [15:3](#); [17:14](#).

Revelation 19:17-19

Gather together for the great banquet: This feast upon the flesh of the armies gathered together to fight against Christ is contrasted with "the wedding feast of the Lamb" ([19:7](#)). The enemies that form for battle are quickly destroyed ([19:20-21](#); see also [14:17-20](#); [16:16-21](#)). Two feasts—the marriage supper of the Lamb ([19:7-8](#)) and the "great supper" of God's judgment ([19:17-18, 21](#))—provide two perspectives on the end of time. They illustrate the two sides of the Good News: grace and judgment, reward and punishment (cp. [John 3:16-18](#)).

Revelation 19:20

beast . . . false prophet See [13:1-10](#). • The fiery lake of burning sulfur provides a picture of eternal punishment (see [20:10, 14-15](#); [21:8](#); see also [Isa 66:24](#); [Matt 13:41, 49-50](#); [Mark 9:43, 48](#)). • God's enemies are thrown into the *fiery lake*. The two beasts ([Rev 19:20](#)) are followed by the dragon ([20:10](#)) and then by death ([20:14](#)) and unsaved humans ([20:15](#)).

Revelation 19:21

The entire army of enemies is dispatched by the sword from Christ's mouth (see [1:16](#); [2:12](#), [16](#); see also [Isa 11:4](#); [49:2](#); [2 Thes 2:8](#)). While one side of God's word (grace) leads to repentance, the other side (judgment) carries out the death sentence.

Revelation 20:1–2

Like the Old Testament “angel of the Lord” (see [Gen 16:7–11](#); [22:15](#); [Exod 3:2](#); [Num 22:22–34](#); [Judg 2:1–4](#); [6:11–22](#)), the angel coming down from heaven has God's authority, symbolized by the key that controls the bottomless pit and the power to put chains on God's great enemy (cp. [Rev 12:7–9](#)) for a thousand years. See “The Thousand Years (The Millennium)” Theme Note.

Revelation 20:1–10

There are three parts to this passage: the binding of Satan ([20:1–3](#)), the reign of God's holy people ([20:4–6](#)), and the release of Satan for his final attempt at a battle ([20:7–10](#)). Four themes emerge: (1) Satan's war is futile—he cannot withstand even an angel; (2) God's holy people will be vindicated and glorified; (3) God will have the final victory; and (4) even when sinful and depraved human beings experience Christ's good purposes in the world, they still flock after Satan when he gains even a small amount of freedom to act.

Revelation 20:3

This incarceration, portrayed as the bottomless pit, is a preliminary defeat for Satan and the powers of evil. Various New Testament passages describe the effect of Christ's work on Satan ([Luke 10:17–20](#); [Acts 10:38](#); [26:18](#); [Rom 16:20](#); [Eph 6:11](#); [Jas 4:7](#); see [Matt 12:24](#); [16:19](#); [18:18](#); [John 12:31](#); [1 Jn 3:8](#)). Christ's presence with his people binds evil powers (see [2 Thes 2:7](#)), reminding persecuted Christians that there is a future with God. • so Satan could not deceive: Deception is the trademark of the devil, who is a liar (see [John 8:44](#); [1 Jn 3:8](#)); no liar will enter heaven ([Rev 21:8](#), [27](#); [22:15](#)). The faithful believers who experience Christ's reign will not be deceived. • The little while might be the equivalent of the symbolic three and a half years (see [11:2–3](#), [9–11](#); [12:14](#); [13:5](#))—it is a limited time.

Revelation 20:4

thrones . . . people sitting on them: This portrayal of a heavenly tribunal includes the elders ([4:4](#)) on thrones (see [Dan 7:9–10](#)), the victorious martyrs (see [Dan 7:22](#)), and all God's people. • beheaded for . . . Jesus: Beheading was a common form of execution for Roman citizens. • The faithful who resisted receiving the mark of the beast ([Rev 13:16–17](#)) will judge the condemned (see [1 Cor 6:2–3](#)) on thrones similar to those of the worshiping elders (see [Rev 4:10–11](#); [5:8–10](#); [11:16](#)).

Revelation 20:5–6

John contrasts the first resurrection with the second death (see [20:12–15](#); cp. [John 5:29](#)).

Revelation 20:6

Blessed: This fifth blessing of Revelation (see also [1:3](#); [14:13](#); [16:15](#); [19:9](#); [22:7](#), [14](#)) focuses on the promised reward of life. God's faithful people ([20:4](#)) will reign with Christ as priests of God (see also [1:6](#); [5:10](#)).

Revelation 20:7–8

When free to act ([20:7](#)), Satan still seeks to deceive. He will gather a mighty army (cp. [Ezek 38–39](#)) in a final attempt to overwhelm God's people ([Rev 20:9](#)).

Revelation 20:7–10

Satan's all-out attempt to conquer God's people is followed by his fiery demise. This passage has two major purposes: (1) to show God's absolute justice, because Satan and his followers are worthy of punishment and will never change; and (2) to show the depravity of people who follow Satan. In spite of viewing the nature of Christ's reign in the world for many years, they still flock to Satan's standard when he is freed. These factors are the basis for the judgment at the great white throne ([20:11–15](#)).

Revelation 20:8

Jewish traditions vary regarding the locations of Gog and Magog. They are symbolically to the north (see [Jer 1:14–15](#)), the direction from which the enemies traditionally approached Megiddo and Jerusalem. The names represent nations and rulers from every corner of the earth that oppose God's people (see [Ezek 38–39](#)). • He will gather them together for battle: Repeating the earlier scenes in which God's enemies assemble for battle ([Rev 16:16](#); [19:19](#)), Satan here makes a last-ditch attempt to confront God and his forces.

Revelation 20:9

Again, no battle occurs (see [16:16–21](#); [19:19–21](#)), because fire from heaven came down ... and consumed them as it did Sodom ([Gen 19:24](#); see also [2 Kgs 1:10–12](#); [Ezek 38:22–23](#); [39:6](#)). The enemies of God cannot stand against him.

Revelation 20:10

they will be tormented . . . forever: Rebellion against God has eternal consequences. While the concept of unending punishment repulses some, it is the message of Revelation and of Scripture generally that God will deal sternly with sin and rebellion by those who reject Christ's saving work (see [Matt 13:42](#); [25:41–46](#); [John 3:18, 36](#); [Rom 2:7](#)). Perhaps more than any book in Scripture, Revelation illustrates that the unrepentant persist in their rebellion despite the consequences ([Rev 9:20–21](#); [16:9–11](#); cp. [Luke 16:31](#)). Revelation also emphasizes that God is just and deals with sin as it deserves.

Revelation 20:11–15

This segment portrays a court hearing at which the dead are judged on the basis of their works. God's response to eternal rebellion is eternal punishment.

Revelation 20:12

books were opened: See [Ps 56:8](#); [Dan 7:10](#). • The Book of Life holds the names of faithful people who have experienced God's saving power ([Mal 3:16](#);

see [Rev 3:5](#); [13:8](#); [17:8](#); [20:15](#)); they are probably the same ones as those who experience the "first resurrection" ([20:5–6](#)). • And the dead were judged: The works of both the redeemed and the unredeemed will be judged (see [22:12](#); [Matt 16:27](#); [25:31–46](#)).

Revelation 20:13

the grave: See study note on 6:7–8.

Revelation 20:14

The expression death and the grave refers to the reality of death; it is the last enemy that God will destroy (see [21:4](#); [1 Cor 15:26](#)). • The lake of fire portrays the horrible end of God's enemies who will not experience the "first resurrection" (see [Rev 20:5–6](#); cp. [Matt 25:41](#); [Luke 16:24](#); [Jude 1:7](#)).

Revelation 21:1

The vision involves God's creation of the new heaven and earth (cp. [Gen 1:1](#) with [Isa 65:17](#); [66:22](#)). The old creation has disappeared—it was subject to decay (see [Rom 8:20–21](#); [2 Pet 3:7, 10](#)). • the sea was also gone: The sea was associated with chaos or the abyss (see study note on [Rev 9:1–12](#)) and was sometimes portrayed as a roaring monster (see [Pss 46:3](#); [74:14](#); see also [Job 3:8](#); [41:1–34](#); [Luke 21:25](#)). The new creation will be free from all such evil.

Revelation 21:1–22.9

The final scenes of the new heaven and earth are striking pictures of a new community and home for God's people that is fashioned and given by God. These scenes help to lift the spirits of persecuted Christians. John lays out his basic vision ([21:1–8](#)) and follows it with two expansions: (1) In [21:9–27](#), he presents the new Jerusalem as the site of holy perfection; (2) in [22:1–5](#), he describes the new Jerusalem as the ultimate Garden of Eden that Adam and Eve could have experienced had they not sinned.

Revelation 21:2

coming down from God: The new creation is a gift from God. In the beginning, God created everything good, and in the end, God will create a new, unbroken world. • This picture of Jerusalem as a beautiful bride (see [Isa 61:10](#)) contrasts starkly with the vision of Babylon (or Rome) as the prostitute ([Rev 17:4-5](#); [18:2-3](#); see study note on 21:9-22:9).

Revelation 21:3

God's home is now among his people! Old and New Testament expectations are fully and finally realized. Ever since humanity sinned ([Gen 3](#)), separation from God has been humanity's greatest problem ([Gen 3:23](#)). God has repeatedly called his people to himself through the prophets, through Jesus his Son, and through the presence of the Spirit (see [Gen 17:8](#); [Exod 29:45-46](#); [Pss 46:4-5](#); [95:7](#); [Jer 7:23](#); [31:33](#); [Ezek 34:14](#); [37:27](#); [Zech 8:8](#); [John 14:2-3](#); [17:24](#)). In the new heaven and new earth, God's people will finally experience ultimate and everlasting fellowship with God.

Revelation 21:4

no more death or sorrow or crying or pain: See [Isa 25:8](#); [1 Cor 15:54](#). God's people will know the creative wholeness and salvation that Christ brings (see [2 Cor 5:17](#); [Gal 6:15](#)).

Revelation 21:6

God restates Jesus' final words from the cross, It is finished! ([John 19:30](#); cp. [Rev 16:17](#)), connecting Christ's death with the assurance of eternal life. • I am the Alpha and the Omega: With the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet, John portrays God as encompassing total reality and total truth. God was from the Beginning (see [Gen 1:1](#); cp. [John 1:1-2](#)) and is also the End (see [Rev 1:8](#); [22:13](#)). • Because Christ is supreme and in charge of all things (see [Rom 9:5](#); [1 Cor 15:28](#); [Eph 1:22-23](#); [4:5-6](#)), he dispenses the water of life to all who are thirsty for it (see study note on Rev 7:16-17; see also [Isa 55:1](#); [John 4:10](#); [7:37-38](#)).

Revelation 21:7

All who are victorious: God's children who persevere in life will inherit his blessings. Adoption is a covenant relationship; the language of adoption certifies their privileges and responsibilities (cp. [Gen 17:8](#); [2 Sam 7:14-16](#); [Jer 31:33](#); [Ezek 34:24](#)).

Revelation 21:8

This vice list summarizes sins described throughout Revelation. These sins characterize people who have not experienced adoption by God; their fate is the fiery lake (see [Rom 1:29-32](#); [Gal 5:19-21](#); [2 Tim 3:2-5](#); cp. [Exod 20:13-17](#); see also study note on Rev 20:10). • all liars: John apparently viewed deception as the root of sin; elsewhere he describes Satan as the "father of lies" ([John 8:44](#); [1 Jn 2:4](#); see [Rev 14:5](#); [21:27](#); [22:15](#); cp. [Matt 12:34](#)).

Revelation 21:9-22:9

This symbolic vision of the new Jerusalem uses vivid word pictures to describe the bride, the wife of the Lamb—all those who respond to Christ's message of salvation (see [21:2](#); [22:17](#); [Eph 5:22-32](#)).

Revelation 21:10

a great, high mountain: In Scripture, experiences with God frequently take place on the mountains (cp. [Ezek 40:2](#); see also [Exod 3:1](#); [19:10-25](#); [Deut 34:1-4](#); [1 Kgs 18:20-40](#); [19:8-18](#); [Matt 5:1](#); [15:29](#); [17:1](#); [24:3](#); [28:16](#)). • the holy city . . . descending out of heaven from God: God's presence and eternal life cannot be reached by human effort but are received as a gift ([Eph 2:8-9](#); cp. [2 Cor 5:1](#)).

Revelation 21:11

Like the true people of God, the glory of the city reflects God's glory (cp. [Exod 34:29-35](#); [2 Cor 3:7-11](#)). • Jasper (see also [Rev 4:3](#); [21:11](#), [18](#)) is opaque on earth; the heavenly jasper is clear as crystal, having a transparency that mirrors God's purity and integrity.

Revelation 21:12-14

In this vision, the twelve tribes of Israel represent the redeemed people of God (see [7:4-8](#); see also [Rom 9:6-7](#)). The foundation for this community of God's redeemed is the twelve apostles of the Lamb. In Jesus, God's promise to bless all of the families of the earth through Abraham has been fully realized ([Gen 12:3](#)).

Revelation 21:15-17

measure the city: Measuring defines accepted boundaries (contrast the unmeasured section of the Temple, [11:2](#); see also [Ezek 40:3-42:20](#)).

Revelation 21:16

The city is described as a perfect cube. Each dimension is 1,400 miles (Greek *12,000 stadia*); the number *12,000* symbolically represents the people of God (see "Symbolic Numbers" Theme Note).

Revelation 21:17

In the ancient world, walls were important not only to the defense and boundary of a city, but also to its status. That these walls are 216 feet thick (Greek *144 cubits*) indicates the strength of God's redeemed people. The measurement of *144 cubits* again uses a multiple of 12 to represent God's people. A cubit was the length of a man's forearm, with a standard length of about 18 inches.

Revelation 21:18

The wall is built of jasper (see study note on 21:11; cp. [4:3](#)). The city is fashioned in gold, which is not opaque like earthly gold; rather, like God's transformed people, the heavenly gold is clear and pure.

Revelation 21:19

The twelve precious stones adorning the foundation stones of the city's wall are a reminder of the twelve stones on the high priests' breastplate that represented the people of God (see [Exod 28:17-20](#)).

Revelation 21:21

Things that are precious and luxurious on earth are common building materials in heaven.

Revelation 21:22

I saw no temple: This apparent conflict with earlier visions ([11:19](#); [14:15-17](#)) is resolved by understanding each visionary picture in Revelation as a separate symbolic representation of God's presence. There is no longer any need for a temple in heaven because God is present with his people.

Revelation 21:23

The vitality, energy, and life of the city are not in institutions or physical sources of power and light, but in the glory of God and the Lamb. The sun and moon were features of the first creation ([Gen 1:14-19](#); see [Isa 60:19-20](#)). • the Lamb is its light: Jesus is the light of the world (see [John 8:12](#); [9:5](#); [12:35-36](#)).

Revelation 21:24-25

The nations: God's promise to Abraham is fulfilled ([Gen 12:3](#); see [Isa 2:3](#)). • In Revelation, the kings of the world usually refer to God's enemies ([Rev 6:15](#); [17:18](#); [18:3](#), [9](#)). Now that the enemies have been destroyed ([16:9](#), [11](#); [19:1-2](#), [19-21](#)), the picture is of God's glory as reflected in those people who have repented ([14:6-7](#); cp. [11:13](#)) and walk with God ([5:9](#); [15:4](#)). • The gates that are never . . . closed contrast with the ancient scene in which closed gates protected cities from enemies, particularly at night. The people enjoy peace and security in God's supremacy (see [Isa 60:11](#)). God's enemies have been destroyed, and fear and failure have ended (see [Zech 14:7](#); [John 11:8-10](#); [12:35-36](#)).

Revelation 21:27

evil (or *ceremonially unclean*): Spiritual impurity is a basic concern in Revelation (see [21:8](#)). Evil is here generalized as idolatry and dishonesty (see [Rev 14:5](#); [21:8](#); [22:15](#)). Those who fail to appear in the Book of Life are excluded from the city of God. Only

those whose names are written in the Book of Life, the pure of heart ([Matt 5:8](#)), will see God.

Revelation 22:1

See [7:17](#); [John 4:10-15](#); cp. [Exod 17:1-7](#); [Isa 55:1](#); [Ezek 47:1-10](#); [Zech 14:8](#).

Revelation 22:1-2

This part of John's vision of the city deals with God's provision of water and food for his people (cp. [Exod 16:4, 22-24](#); [Ezek 47:1-12](#); [John 4:10; 6:32-35](#)). Although God originally made a "garden of delight" (Eden) for Adam and Eve, they disobeyed him and lost it ([Gen 2-3](#)). Now Eden is refashioned and united to the celestial city as God's marvelous gift for his faithful people.

Revelation 22:2

Although humans were denied access to the tree of life after they sinned (see [Gen 3:22-24](#)), it is now freely available. The tree on each side of the river (cp. [Ezek 47:12](#)) shows that there is no wrong side of the river in heaven. The tree produces a fresh crop of fruit each month, demonstrating God's constant provision.

Revelation 22:3

No longer . . . a curse: Ever since the first sin ([Gen 3:14-19](#)), humanity has been cursed because of their rebellion against God (see [1 Cor 16:22](#)). Now rebellion, sin, and the curse are gone forever. • his servants will worship him: Revelation gives glimpses of authentic worship (see [Rev 4-5](#); [7:9-17](#)).

Revelation 22:4

The human fears of death and of seeing God (see [Gen 16:13](#); [32:30](#); [Judg 6:22](#); [Isa 6:5](#)) will be removed. God's people will bear his name and will see his face with joy (see [Matt 5:8](#); [2 Cor 3:18](#); [1 Jn 3:2-3](#)).

Revelation 22:5

They will reign with God forever (see [20:4](#); see also [5:10](#)) in his radiant light that banishes night and the need for lamps (see [Isa 60:19-20](#)).

Revelation 22:6

Everything that John records in Revelation is trustworthy and true because God, who has all authority (cp. [Matt 28:18](#)), has sent the messenger. But it does not mean these visions are easy to understand.

Revelation 22:6-21

This epilogue to Revelation contains utterances by an angel ([22:6, 8-11](#)) and Christ ([22:7, 12-19](#)) followed by a concluding plea for Christ's return ([22:20](#)) and a closing benediction ([22:21](#)). The epilogue has a number of direct verbal connections with the introduction to the book ([1:1-11](#)), and it sums up important themes such as encouraging faithful perseverance, warning evildoers, affirming the authenticity of the prophetic message, and restating the nearness of Christ's return.

Revelation 22:7

Blessed: The sixth blessing of Revelation (see [1:3](#); [14:13](#); [16:15](#); [19:9](#); [20:6](#); [22:14](#)) is for those who obey. Obedience is key to God's blessing.

Revelation 22:8-9

The earlier warning against false worship (see [19:10](#)) is reiterated when John again falls at the feet of the angel. Only God deserves our worship (cp. John the Baptist in relation to Jesus; [John 1:6-8, 26-27](#); [3:27-35](#)).

Revelation 22:10

Do not seal up: The angel expands John's initial instruction to "write in a book" ([1:11](#)) and warns against curtailing its communication. Although some things are sealed—God does not reveal everything (cp. [10:4](#))—what has been written must be communicated so that people will understand

the seriousness of the message and that the time is near (see [1:1, 3](#); [22:6–7](#); cp. [Dan 12:4](#)).

Revelation 22:11

Vile people who refuse to accept God's forgiveness will continue to be vile (see [16:9](#)), yet John reminds the righteous to maintain their integrity. This verse is a warning to evildoers, and it calls the righteous to recognize the crucial significance of Christ's return relative to their commitments and their actions.

Revelation 22:12

Christ is coming soon ... to repay all people, not just on the basis of their profession of faith, but according to their deeds (see [2:23](#); [11:18](#); [14:13](#); [20:12–13](#); see also [Prov 24:12](#); [Matt 16:27](#); [2 Cor 5:10](#)). Not every statement of belief is genuine ([John 2:23–25](#)); faith will show itself in actions ([Jas 2:14–26](#)). We are indeed saved by the grace and power of God in Christ. Our works do not save us, but they do indicate the seriousness of our confession and provide a just basis for our ultimate reward or punishment.

Revelation 22:14

Blessed are those: In response to the connection between actions and ultimate results ([22:12](#)), the seventh blessing of Revelation (see also [1:3](#); [14:13](#); [16:15](#); [19:9](#); [20:6](#); [22:7](#)) promises acceptance for those who wash their robes—those who have been purified by trusting in Christ and following him faithfully ([3:5](#); [6:11](#); [7:9–10, 14](#); [19:13](#); [Eph 5:26](#); [Heb 10:22](#)). • enter through the gates of the city: See study note on Rev 21:24–25.

Revelation 22:15

This verse again lists those who are not admitted to contrast with those admitted in [22:14](#) (see [21:8, 27](#); [22:11](#)). These unrepentant sinners remain outside the city; it is another warning to those who do not repent that they will not be allowed to enter the city of God ([22:14](#)). • The reference to sinners as dogs was a familiar Jewish designation for rejected outsiders (see [Matt 7:6](#); [Phil 3:2](#); also [2](#)

[Sam 3:8](#); [2 Kgs 8:13](#)); Jews used this term to refer to Gentiles (see [Mark 7:26–28](#)).

Revelation 22:16

I am both the source of David and the heir to his throne: Jesus validates the message of Revelation (cp. [John 21:24](#)) by swearing that he is simultaneously *the source of David* (see [Rev 5:5](#); [Isa 11:10](#)) and David's *heir* (see [Ezek 37:23–24](#); [Rom 1:3](#)). • The morning star was a name for the Messiah (see [Num 24:17](#); [2 Pet 1:19](#); cp. [Luke 1:78–79](#)).

Revelation 22:17

Come is a repeated invitation and a confession (see [22:20](#)). • the bride: The Lamb's wife (see [21:9](#)) is the church, the people of God. • The thirsty can drink freely from God's provision (see [21:6](#); [22:1](#); [Ps 42:1](#); [Isa 55:1](#); [John 4:10–14](#)).

Revelation 22:18–19

I solemnly declare: John issues an oath to protect the integrity of the book of Revelation. He declares a curse upon anyone who alters the contents of the book or its message (cp. [Deut 4:2](#); [12:32](#)). The curse contrasts with the statement of blessing on all who read aloud, listen to, and obey the prophecy ([Rev 1:3](#)). At the time Revelation was written, scribes would sometimes alter books to suit their own views. Early Christians quickly developed means of authenticating both messages and messengers (see [John 21:24](#); [1 Cor 16:21](#); [Gal 6:11](#); [Col 4:18](#); [2 Thes 3:17](#); [1 Jn 4:1–3](#)). • Since the time of the early church, the scope and content of the New Testament has been established as the measure of the Christian proclamation. Yet the church continues to be plagued by those who would attempt to reconstruct the borders of Scripture by adding other works that they believe are of equal status with the Bible or by arguing that certain segments of the Bible are unreliable creations of human effort and perception. The genuine church has rejected and will continue to reject efforts to redefine the boundaries of the canon as human and even demonic attempts to alter the basis of the Christian faith.

Revelation 22:20

I am coming soon! See [3:11](#). • Come, Lord Jesus! Paul uttered the same response ([1 Cor 16:22](#); see also [Phil 4:5](#)).

Revelation 22:21

Revelation closes with a benediction similar to those in Paul's letters (e.g., [Rom 15:33](#); [1 Cor 16:23-24](#)). • The fitting final sentence invokes the grace of the Lord Jesus, the foundation of our forgiveness and the basis of our eternal hope.